

CM announces semiconductor policy

Govt bets big on road redevelopment

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Delhi's roads, long choked, broken, and dusty, have found themselves at the centre of the Chief Minister Rekha Gupta Government's second budget, with thousands of crores earmarked to rebuild, repair, and reimagine the Capital's street network.

Presenting a ₹1.03 lakh crore budget for 2026-27, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced a sweeping set of road-focused measures. These include large allocations for road construction, redevelopment, decongestion, and dust control. The push signals a clear attempt to fix one of the city's most visible and persistent civic problems.

At the core of the plan is a ₹12,613 crore allocation for transport and roads. A significant portion will go towards



GOURAV

upgrade road quality and expand capacity where necessary.

A major highlight is the redevelopment of 750 km of roads across Delhi. For this, ₹1,392 crore has been set aside. The project will focus on end-to-end repair and strengthening of road stretches, with an emphasis on durable, brick-and-mortar pavement. Officials stated that the goal is to create roads that are more durable and can withstand heavy traffic and adverse weather conditions.

In a parallel move, the government has earmarked ₹1,352 crore for making Delhi's roads "dust-free". This will include mechanical sweeping, better maintenance, and targeted interventions to reduce road dust: a major contributor to air pollution in the city.

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD),

which manages a large share of internal roads, will receive unprecedented financial support. The budget provides ₹11,666 crore to the civic body: the highest ever allocation, along with an additional ₹1,000 crore specifically for road improvement works. This is expected to boost repair and maintenance of smaller roads and neighbourhood streets, which often remain neglected.

The government has also allocated ₹500 crore for decongestion projects. These are aimed at easing traffic bottlenecks through infrastructure upgrades and better traffic flow management. Among key ongoing projects, the Barapullah Phase III corridor is expected to be completed by June 2026. The corridor is seen as crucial for reducing travel time between East and South Delhi.

Govt allocates ₹7,406 crore to Women and Child Development department

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

From two free LPG cylinders and free bus rides to the Mahila Samridhhi Yojana and free bicycles for 1.3 lakh girl students, from the setting up of 'Rani Haat' to link their skills with markets, subsidies and welfare schemes remain a key feature of the Delhi budget presented by the Rekha Gupta Government on Tuesday. The current budget places strong emphasis on women's welfare, with multiple schemes aimed at financial empowerment, safety, mobility, and social security.

The Delhi Government allocated ₹7,406 crore to the Women and Child Development department in the 2026-27 Budget.

Besides, ₹450 crore has been allocated for free bus



ment's most ambitious schemes, under which a total of ₹61,000 will be deposited in the accounts of girls from birth till graduation, maturing to ₹1.20 lakh. She proposed an allocation of ₹128 crore for the scheme.

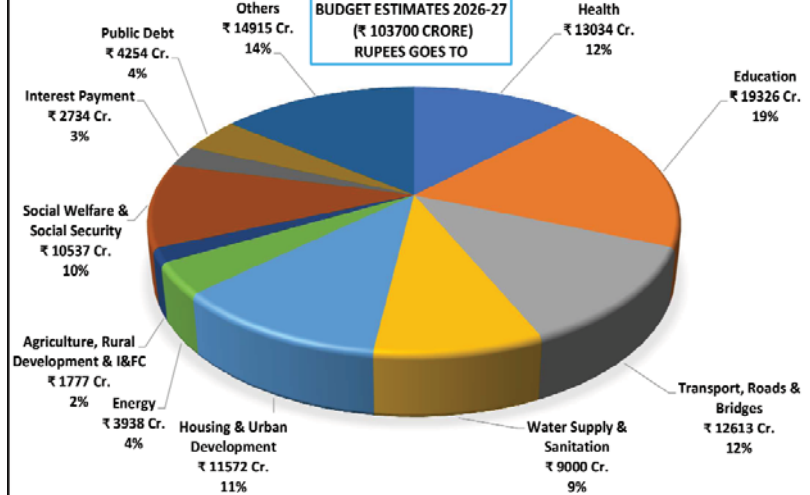
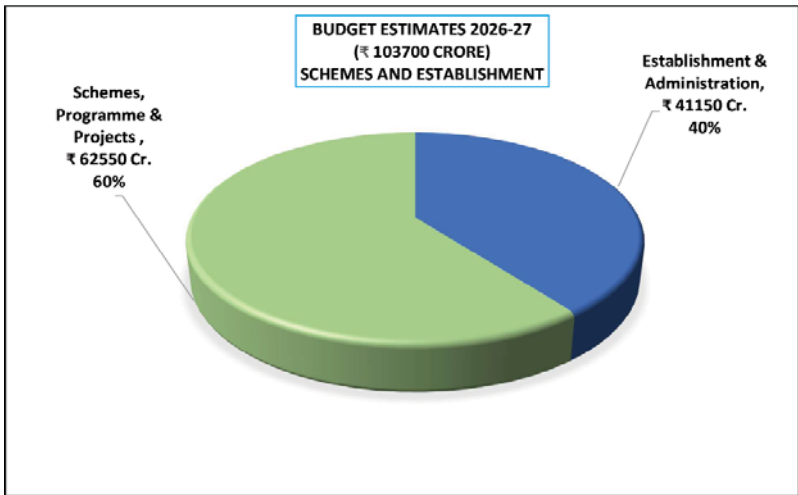
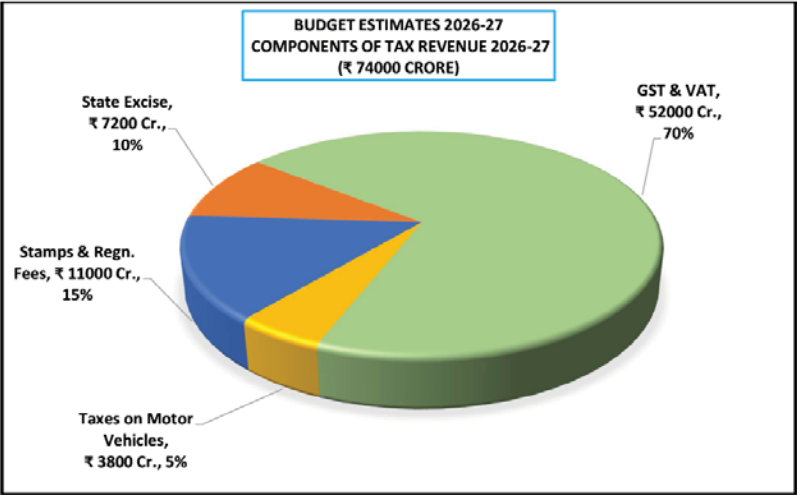
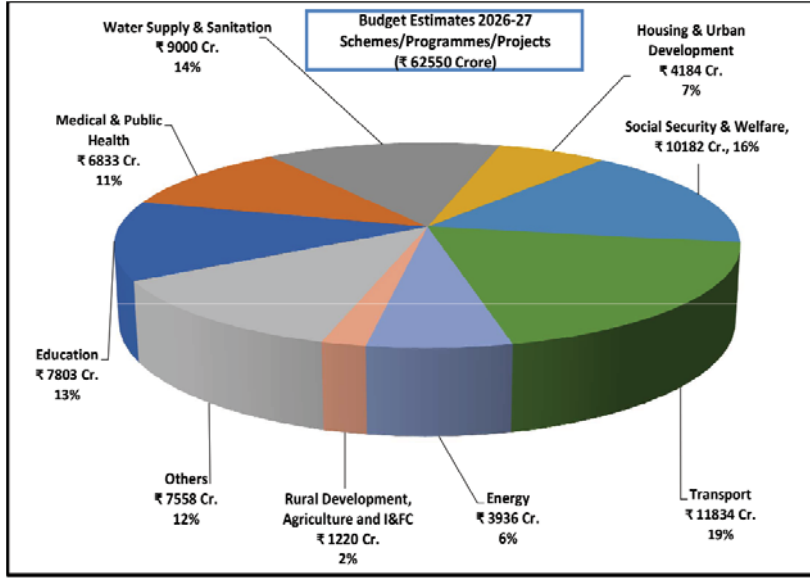
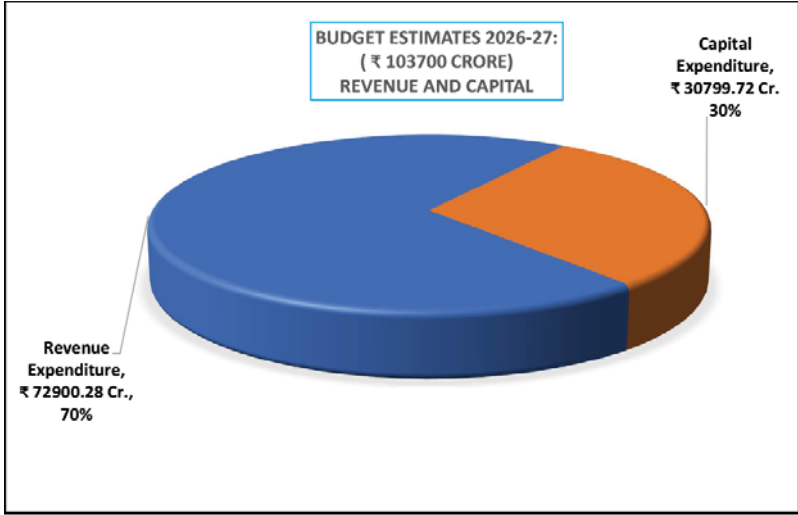
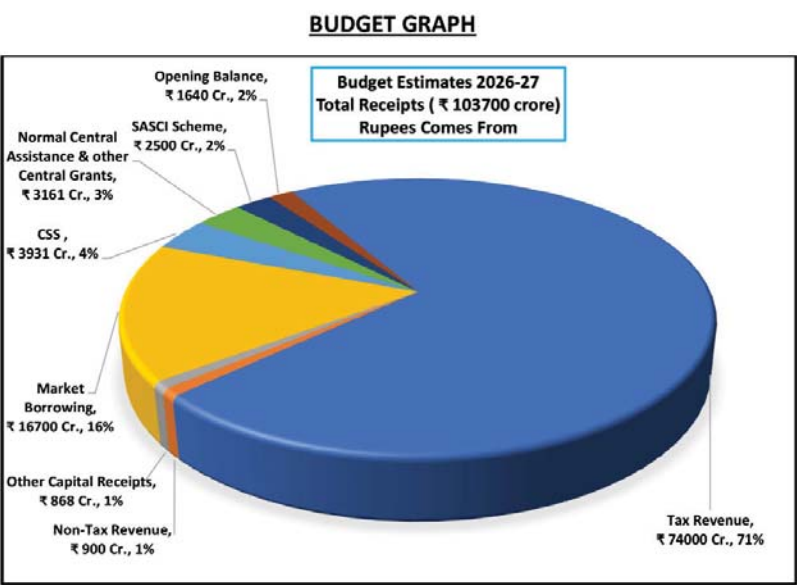
Last month, the Government announced that the Ladli Yojana, launched in 2008, would be replaced by the Lakhpati Betiya Yojana from April this year, as a large amount of unclaimed funds had accumulated under the previous scheme.

To promote self-reliance, the government will launch the 'DURGA' (Driving Upliftment and Rozgar for Women/Transgender Green e-Auto) scheme, under which 1,000 women and 100 transgender persons will be assisted in obtaining new auto-rickshaw permits in 2026-27, Gupta said.

travel for women, continuing existing schemes.

Presenting her second budget, the chief minister Rekha Gupta announced a new budget of ₹260 crore is proposed in BE 2026-27 for providing free gas cylinders on the occasion of Holi and Deepawali to ration cardholder families in Delhi, expanding the scope of direct household support.

Announcing the proposals, the chief minister said the "Delhi Lakhpati Betiya Yojana" is among the govern-



Govt earmarks ₹19,326 cr for education sector

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government earmarked ₹19,326 crore for the education sector in 2026-27, the lion's share of its Budget, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announcing a Sainik School in the capital and free bicycles for 1.30 lakh Class IX girl students.

Tabling the Budget, the chief minister said the government will introduce a "Private Play Schools Policy" to regulate the play school under a framework and a common library infrastructure, along with a digital library system to ensure equal access to knowledge resources for students, she added.

The chief minister said around 1,30,000 girl students studying in Class IX will be provided free bicycles to make it easier for them to



reach school, with an allocation of ₹90 crore for the scheme.

To empower the youth with discipline, patriotism and leadership qualities, the Delhi government will set up a Sainik School in the city for the first time and demanded that the Centre provide 10 Kendriya Vidyalayas in the national capital.

The allocation for the edu-

cation sector this year is slightly higher than last year's ₹19,291 crore, which had also received the highest share of the total budget.

The Government has proposed ₹5 crore to establish medical rooms in every government school in 2026-27. It has also earmarked ₹2 crore for providing creche facilities in offices with designated caregivers, she said.

Delhi targets water woes with ₹9,000 crore push

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a city where water often arrives with uncertainty: too little, too late, or not at all, the Delhi Government has placed a big bet on fixing the system that delivers it. A ₹9,000 crore allocation in the 2026-27 Budget signals an aggressive push to repair, expand, and modernise the capital's water network.

Presenting the Budget in the Assembly, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the focus is on strengthening supply lines, cutting leakages, and upgrading treatment capacity. The aim is simple but ambitious: ensure reliable and equitable access to potable water across Delhi.

A key part of the plan involves expanding the physical network. The Government will lay 12.7 km of new transmission lines and 172 km of distribution

pipelines. These additions are expected to improve reach and efficiency in several parts of the city.

Water supply is also set to increase. The government plans to add 10 million gallons per day (MGD) in the immediate phase, with a larger target of 36 MGD in the pipeline. But the sharper challenge lies in reducing losses. Nearly 45 per cent of Delhi's water currently goes unaccounted for as "non-revenue water". The Government now aims to bring this down to 15 per cent. This will involve fixing leakages, improving monitoring, and tightening distribution systems.

The Chief Minister said the broader goal is to ensure that every household in Delhi has access to tap water. One of the flagship projects in this effort is the expansion of the Chandrawal Water Treatment Plant.

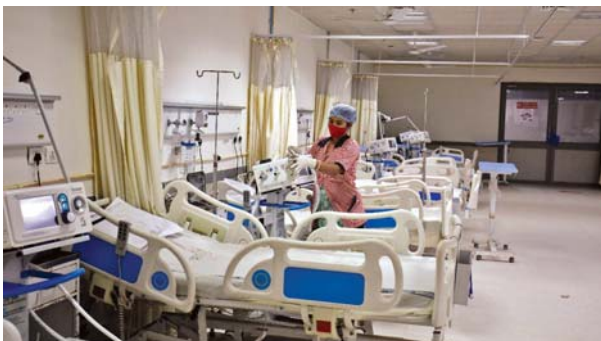
Govt allocates over 12.5% of its total budget to healthcare sector

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has allocated over 12.5 per cent of its total Budget to the healthcare sector in FY 2026-27, amounting to about ₹13,034 crore, with provisions for free genetic testing for newborns, expansion of Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, inclusion of transgender persons under the PM-JAY scheme, and a push for better healthcare infrastructure.

Chief Minister and Finance Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday presented a ₹1.03 lakh crore Budget for FY27, announcing several welfare initiatives. The health allocation marks an increase of 1 per cent from ₹12,893 crore in 2025-26.

"This year, we focus on 'Accessible Healthcare and Secure Life'. The goal is to build a strong, accessible and affordable healthcare



system, from primary to intensive care, where treatment is a right, not a privilege," she said.

A key highlight is the launch of the ANMOL (Advanced Newborn Monitoring for Optimal Lifecare) scheme with an allocation of ₹25 crore.

Under this initiative, 56 types of tests will be conducted using a single drop of blood from newborns, completely free of cost in both

public and private hospitals. "Children are dear to all, they are 'anmol'. To prevent genetic disorders, which are extremely expensive to treat, we are launching this scheme," the Chief Minister said.

The government also announced the inclusion of transgender persons under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PM-JAY), with a proposed allocation of ₹202 crore.

20 million lives at risk: CAG delivers damning verdict on Delhi's worsening water crisis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India has delivered a damning verdict on the functioning of the Delhi Jal Board (DJB). Its Performance Audit Report No. 3 of 2025, laid before the Delhi Legislative Assembly on March 23, 2026, paints a picture of chronic mismanagement amid the Capital's worsening water crisis.

The report is a wake-up call. Delhi's 20 million residents continue to suffer erratic supply, contaminated water and choked drains while the Yamuna remains severely polluted. Without swift implementation of the CAG's rec-

ommendations, the Capital's water and sewerage infrastructure risks total collapse.

Spanning seven chapters, the report reveals how shortages, leakages, pollution, financial losses and administrative failures have left millions of Delhiites without reliable drinking water or proper sewerage services.

Chapter 2 of the report highlights the widening gap in raw water availability. Between 2017-18 and 2021-22, the shortage of raw water rose from 22 per cent to 24 per cent, while the shortfall in potable water increased from 24.2 per cent to 25.79 per cent. The primary reasons cited are insufficient raw water sources, inadequate treatment capacity and



the board's failure to augment supply. It may be noted that the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) was running the government in the national capital in this period.

Shockingly, the absence of flow

meters at Water Treatment Plants (WTPs), reservoirs, bore wells and emergency points meant DJB could not accurately measure how much water was being treated, transmitted or supplied.

Water quality testing also fell far short of Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) norms, putting public health at risk. The distribution network fares no better. Transmission losses climbed from 16 per cent to 21 per cent during the audit period. Per capita availability of potable water remained abysmal: four zones received less than 20 gallons per capita per day (GPCD) and eight zones less than 40 GPCD, against the required 60 GPCD.

This inequitable supply has hit poorer colonies hardest. Non-Revenue Water (NRW) water lost to leaks, theft and unmetered supply—hovered between 51 and 53 per cent, resulting in a staggering revenue loss of ₹4,988 crores.

Audit Alert: CAG Verdict on DJB (2025)

- Status: A "damning verdict" on chronic mismanagement and financial instability.
- Period Audited: Primarily 2017-18 to 2021-22 (under the AAP government).
- WATER SCARCITY & QUALITY
 - Widening Gap: Raw water shortage rose to 24%; potable water shortfall reached 25.79%.
 - Abysmal Supply: Residents in some zones received less than 20 GPCD (Gallons Per Capita per Day), far below the required 60 GPCD.
 - Health Risk: Water quality testing consistently fell short of BIS norms; a lack of flow

- meters meant treated water could not be accurately measured.
- FINANCIAL & RESOURCE HEMORRHAGE
 - Revenue Loss: ₹4,988 crore lost due to Non-Revenue Water (leaks, theft, and unmetered supply).
 - Debt Trap: Outstanding loans and interest reached a staggering ₹66,595 crore (as of March 2022).
 - The "Meter" Crisis: Only 40% of potable water produced was billed; of that, only 66% was based on actual meter readings.

IN FOCUS



Women perform rituals in the Ganga river during 'Chaiti Chhath' festival in Patna

PTI

Athawale thanks PM for Rajya Sabha term

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister of State for Social Justice and Empowerment Ramdas Athawale called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday for a courtesy meeting.

During the meeting, Athawale expressed heartfelt gratitude and thanks to the Prime Minister for nominating him for a third term as a Member of the Rajya Sabha.

He described the nomination as a symbol of Prime Minister Modi's trust and guidance, and assured that he would continue to work shoulder-to-shoulder with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) for social justice, inclusive development and the empowerment of deprived sections of society.

He also raised the issue of



increasing scholarships for students belonging to Scheduled Castes (SC) and Other Backward Classes (OBC) before the Prime Minister, so that youth from these communities can get better opportunities in education and employment.

At the end of the meeting, he stated that in the coming days, he will extensively propagate the ideology of Babasaheb Dr BR Ambedkar, social harmony, and the core values of the Constitution across the country, and will work towards reaching the welfare schemes of the NDA Government to every citizen.

India 6th most polluted; UP's Loni worst in world: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India is the sixth most-polluted country when it comes to levels of fine particulate matter, a major air pollutant, while UP's Loni is the most polluted city across the globe, and Delhi is at the fourth spot, according to the World Air Quality Report, 2025.

The eighth edition of the report published by IQAir, a Swiss air quality technology company, analysed data from monitoring stations across 9,446 cities in 143 countries, regions and territories.

According to the report, Pakistan is the most polluted country, followed by Bangladesh, Tajikistan, Chad and Congo, with India at the sixth spot. Among the ten most polluted cities across the globe, five are from India: Loni, Byrnihat, Delhi, Ghaziabad and Ula. "The world's 25 most polluted cities were all located in India, Pakistan and



China, with India home to three of the four most polluted. Loni, India, was the most polluted city, recording an annual average PM2.5 concentration of 112.5 µg/m³—a nearly 23 per cent increase from 2024 and more than 22 times the WHO guideline," the report said.

Comparing this year's report to the previous year, 54 countries experi-

enced a rise in the annual average of PM2.5, 75 saw a drop, two remained unchanged, and 12 were newly represented in this year's dataset.

"Only 14 per cent of global cities met the World Health Organisation (WHO) annual PM2.5 guideline of 5 µg/m³, down from 17 per cent the previous year.

Statues of Kakori martyrs razed in Shahjahanpur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shahjahanpur (UP)

Statues of the Kakori train action martyrs were demolished using a bulldozer, allegedly during a road construction work in Shahjahanpur, sparking outrage with Opposition parties, including the Samajwadi Party (SP), on Tuesday, demanding action against those responsible for it.

The statues of freedom fighters Ram Prasad Bismil, Ashfaqulla Khan and Roshan Singh, who hailed from Shahjahanpur, were installed along a road outside the municipal corporation office and were regularly garlanded by visiting public representatives. They were allegedly demolished on Sunday night.

A video purportedly showing the statues being razed and their debris dumped at a garbage site was posted on social media, drawing sharp reactions. Municipal sources said the



demolition was carried out by a contractor engaged in road construction and beautification work. After being dismantled, the remains of the statues were reportedly dumped at a waste disposal site, and the plaques installed at the site were also removed using a bulldozer. Samajwadi Party (SP) district president Tanveer Khan alleged that the statues were demolished to remove a plaque bearing his name that had been installed during his tenure as municipal chairman.

He termed the incident an

"insult to the martyrs" and accused the administration of acting arbitrarily.

Reacting to the incident, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav said that beautification can never take precedence over respect for martyrs.

Freedom fighters Ram Prasad Bismil, Ashfaqulla Khan and Roshan Singh were hanged by the British on December 19, 1927, for looting a train that was carrying Government funds in August 1925 near Kakori, Lucknow. Sharing a news report on social media platform X, the SP chief con-

demned the demolition, calling it a reflection of a "disturbing mindset". Uttar Pradesh Congress chief Ajay Rai demanded strict action against those responsible for the demolition.

"If justice is not served, every single Congress worker will take to the streets and fiercely oppose this dictatorship," he said in a post on X.

Rai said that the "BJP Government's municipal corporation ran bulldozers over the statues of great revolutionaries like Pandit Ram Prasad Bismil, Ashfaqulla Khan, and Thakur Roshan Singh.

"This is a direct assault on every brave hero who laid down their life for the country's freedom and on the sentiments of 145 crore Indians. The Yogi Government must immediately take strict action against the responsible officials." Meanwhile, a descendant of Ashfaqulla Khan said the act was condemnable and vowed to protest against it.

INS Nilgiri reaches Sydney for fleet review



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indigenous stealth frigate INS Nilgiri, the lead ship of India's Project 17A, has reached Sydney to take part in an international fleet review being hosted by the Royal Australian Navy to mark its 125th anniversary, officials said on Tuesday.

It reached Sydney on March 21 after the completion of phase one of Exercise Kakadu — Royal Australian Navy's (RAN) maritime multilateral drill, they said.

The visit marks a significant milestone in the ship's overseas deployment and underscores the growing maritime cooperation between India and Australia, an Indian Navy spokesperson said.

INS Nilgiri's deployment in the southern hemisphere and in the Western Pacific, alongside a multitude of foreign navies, highlights India's growing role in building a secure, cooperative, and rules-based maritime order across the larger Indo-Pacific region, the Indian Navy said.

Vice Admiral Sanjay Bhalla, Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Eastern Naval Command, would head the Indian

delegation that will participate in various multilateral activities associated with RAN's International Fleet Review (IFR).

Rear Admiral Alok Ananda, Flag Officer Commanding, Eastern Fleet, would represent the Indian Navy in the Fleet Commanders' Conference as a part of the IFR.

During the port call, a series of professional and multilateral engagements are scheduled, aimed at enhancing mutual understanding, interoperability, and maritime collaboration in the Indo-Pacific region, the spokesperson said.

As part of the visit, INS Nilgiri will participate in various professional discussions, exercise planning activities, subject matter expert exchanges, and sporting fixtures, the official said.

In the recently concluded IFR at Visakhapatnam in February this year, RAN was represented by HMAS Warramunga, an ANZAC-class frigate.

INS Nilgiri's participation in RAN's IFR is thus a symbol of "mutual respect and acknowledgement" of the growing partnership between the two navies, the spokesperson said.

South-East Asia bears high TB burden, says WHO official

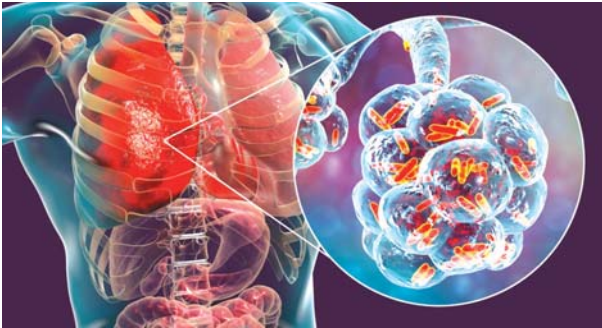
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The South-East Asia region continues to carry a disproportionate share of the tuberculosis burden, one of the leading infectious diseases in the world, said a World Health Organisation (WHO) official said on Tuesday.

On the World TB Day, the WHO called for stronger national leaderships, sustained investment and continued engagement of communities and people to control the spread of the disease.

In a statement, Dr Catharina Boehme, officer-in-charge, WHO South-East Asia, said, "The region accounts for approximately 34 per cent of people developing the disease globally and nearly 40 per cent of deaths.

In 2024 alone, an estimated 3.68 million people devel-



oped TB, and approximately 433,000 lives were lost, including 13,000 among people living with HIV," she said in a statement.

This year's theme — "Yes! We Can End TB" — is a timely reminder that progress is within reach when political commitment, science and innovation, and community leadership come together, Dr Boehme said.

Since 2015, South-East Asia has achieved 23 per cent

reduction in TB deaths, and 16 per cent decline in TB incidence, outpacing the global average decline of 12 per cent.

"Treatment coverage has expanded significantly to more than 85 per cent, with over 3.1 million people initiating treatment in 2024. The member states continue to achieve treatment success rates above the global average, including for drug-resistant TB, she said."

RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat pushes for three-child policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mathura

Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat on Tuesday raised concerns over illegal immigration in India, asking people to keep a close watch to identify intruders and report them to authorities. He also reiterated his push for a three-child policy, stressing the need for higher birth rates, while also discouraging "forced" religious conversions.

Speaking after inaugurating an ashram in Mathura, Bhagwat highlighted the issue of illegal immigration and said, "People need to keep a closer watch to identify foreigners and ensure that they do not receive employment here."

He, however, said that there should be no discrimination against Indian citizens. Bhagwat's remarks on intruders come at a time when Assembly elections are due in multiple States — including Assam and West Bengal, where the issue of illegal immigrants has garnered a lot of traction of late. The BJP has also been talking about it frequently.



Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat

On family health and population, the RSS chief said doctors recommend three children for sound family health, as childhood interactions help individuals develop social skills and the ability to adjust within a group. He said population studies warn that a fertility rate below three poses long-term risks.

"Countries with low birth rates have actively sought to increase their population above three," he said. Bhagwat urged reconsideration of India's population policy, stressing that while legal measures can be applied, public understanding is

crucial first. A humanitarian approach requires families to aim for three children rather than two, he said, asserting that this is essential for the welfare of society. Bhagwat also called for an end to forced religious conversions. "The Government may legislate, but society must stop this on its own. Many who converted to other religions are descendants of Hindus and may wish to return. Those willing should be welcomed back," he said.

The RSS chief also cited the "aggressive" nature of countries like the US and China, and hailed India as more accommodating of others' viewpoints. "The US may come around and say that our economic model is the best, and everyone should follow it. China may say our model is best suited for everyone. However, India's approach is not about imposing on others; it believes everyone's viewpoint is correct. It is about living according to dharma, truth and cultural pride. The world may be aggressive, but our model emphasises ethical conduct, which the global community can learn

from," he said.

Bhagwat said he had come to inaugurate the ashram out of "affection", as ashrams play a crucial role in shaping life perspective, promoting pride in one's religion and culture while discouraging aggression.

They are necessary in today's times, he said, pointing out that the term "ashram" is unique to Indian culture, without an equivalent translation in any other language. "An ashram is first a school where life knowledge is taught. Those who stay disciplined and study here can serve society effectively for decades while nurturing their own character," he said. Bhagwat highlighted that the ultimate human pursuit is moksha, or liberation.

He explained the four types of human endeavours, with the fourth being dharma, which is imparted through ashram education and holds immense importance.

He also compared traditional Indian education with global systems, noting that even Finland's acclaimed education model mirrors the Gurukul-ashram approach.

Government calls all-party meet on West...

Acknowledging the constantly changing situation, he called upon citizens to remain prepared for every eventuality. Modi also assured that the safety of lives and livelihoods of around one crore Indians in the Gulf is a major concern, noting that around 3,75,000 Indians have returned safely, including 1,000 from Iran. "The uninterrupted supply of essential commodities must be the topmost priority for every state, and I earnestly appeal to all state Governments to put special arrangements in place to ensure this," he said.

The opposition, led by Congress, hit out at the Government, calling the PM's statement on the crisis a "prepared text full of self-praise."

Delhi unveils `1.03 lakh crore budget

To improve access to education, the Government will provide transportation for schoolchildren and ₹90 crore for bicycles for 1.3 lakh girls. Merit-based initiatives include laptops for high-performing Class 10 students, ₹150 crore for smart classrooms, and an Integrated Education Hub in Narela. ₹10 crore has been allocated for youth talent-hunt programmes, and a Sainik School will be established in Delhi.

Subsidies and welfare remain significant,

with ₹3,500 crore for power subsidies and ₹450 crore for free bus travel for women. A new ₹260 crore provision will fund free LPG cylinders for ration card holders during festivals.

The budget, described by the CM as a "green budget," allocates 21 per cent of total expenditure for environmentally sustainable initiatives. Power infrastructure will receive ₹3,942 crore, including ₹200 crore to shift overhead electricity wires underground.

For urban and regional development, ₹300 crore has been set aside for the trans-Yamuna area, while ₹787 crore is allocated to the Delhi Gram Vikas Board. Water and sewage management projects have been funded with ₹9,000 crore to the Delhi Jal Board.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta highlighted that 70.3 per cent of the budget is for revenue expenditure and 29.7 per cent for capital expenditure, with a higher capital outlay than last year. She projected a tax-to-GSDP ratio of 5.09 per cent for 2026-27 and a revenue surplus of ₹9,092 crore. The CM emphasized Delhi's resilience and economic progress, stating that the city is moving ahead at "triple-engine speed," and underscored visible development in people's lives.

The budget session began amid political tension, with AAP MLAs staging a protest with a 'bier' alleging a "murder" of democracy by the ruling BJP, while the Assembly received a bomb threat hours before the presentation. Police, however, reported no suspicious findings so far.

FROM PAGE - 1 Harish Rana passes away at AIIMS

This decision reinforced the principle that the right to die with dignity is part of the right to life. With court approval granted, Rana was shifted to palliative care at AIIMS, marking a transition from aggressive to comfort-focused treatment. Doctors then began to gradually withdraw the interventions keeping him alive.

Despite the legal clarity, the emotional burden remained with the family. For years, Rana's bedroom had become a space of waiting: where festivals were marked quietly, conversations continued in hope, and time seemed to stand still. His parents and loved ones remained present through it all, refusing to give up even as medical possibilities narrowed. Those close to the family said the final days were marked by acceptance rather than expectation.

Rana's prolonged condition had also exposed the practical challenges families face in end-of-life decisions. While the Supreme Court has laid down guidelines on passive euthanasia and living wills, implementation often remains complex, involving multiple approvals and medical reviews. Even so, Rana's case helped bring clarity to the legal framework and sparked wider public discussion on dignity in death. Doctors say patients in a persistent vegetative state can survive for years with artificial support, but recovery in such cases is extremely rare once the con-

dition becomes prolonged.

Rana's death, therefore, was not unexpected medically, but it carried emotional weight for those who had followed his journey. For his family, it marked the end of a 13-year wait: a period defined by care, uncertainty, and difficult choices. His story leaves behind more than a legal precedent. It leaves a reminder of the human cost behind such cases, where decisions are not just clinical or legal, but deeply personal. With his passing, a case that once stood in courtrooms now rests in the memory of a man who lay silent for years, and a family that stayed, until the end.

No SC benefits after conversion, rules...

The high court had quashed charges filed by a complainant who had converted to Christianity but invoked the Act in a criminal case.

Challenging the decision, the complainant, a pastor, moved the Supreme Court.

Dismissing his plea, the apex court noted there was no claim of reconversion or re-acceptance into his original Madiga community. On the contrary, evidence showed he had been practising Christianity for over a decade and was conducting regular prayer meetings in his village.

The court said these facts left "no room for doubt" that he remained a Christian at the time of the alleged incident. The case stemmed from a 2021 complaint filed by the pastor,

Chinthada Anand, against Akkala Rami Reddy in Andhra Pradesh. He had alleged assault, death threats and caste-based abuse while conducting Sunday prayers, invoking provisions of the Indian Penal Code and the SC/ST Act.

Supreme Court grants full pension to women officers

Using powers under Article 142 of the Constitution, the court ruled that, as a one-time measure, all SSC officers considered for PC in selection boards held in 2019, 2020, and 2021, including those released in 2021, will be deemed to have completed 20 years of qualifying service. Pensions will be fixed accordingly, effective November 1, 2025. While the court declined to order reinstatement, citing "operational effectiveness," it clarified that this cannot bar officers from receiving financial benefits.

For the Army and Navy, the court identified similar flaws in assessment models and noted that non-disclosure of evaluation criteria adversely impacted women officers. However, the plea for notional time-scale promotions to Wing Commander for those not in active service was rejected. The Centre had earlier defended its policy, claiming the Army's processes were gender-neutral and that "elimination is part of a policy to keep the forces young." The detailed judgment is awaited.

Women’s Reservation Act: Govt to call special session

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government is likely to convene a special session of Parliament to pass the proposed amendments to the Women’s Reservation Act, as the Opposition demanded an all-party meeting to discuss the matter. Earlier, the Centre was mulling over bringing the bill in the ongoing Budget session.

The Women’s Reservation Act, passed in 2023, provides for 33 per cent reservation for women in both the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, but it has yet to be implemented due to the pending delimitation exercise. The proposed amendments to the act aim to delink its implementation from the delayed delimitation exercise currently slated for 2027-28.

Several Opposition parties on Tuesday wrote to the Government, asking for an all-party meeting to be convened to discuss the modalities of the implementation of the women’s quota law.

In a letter to Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju, the Opposition leaders said the meeting should be held after the current round of assembly elections is completed in April.

“You may recall that I had written to you on March 16,



PM Narendra Modi, Union Ministers Amit Shah, S Jaishankar, Nirmala Sitharaman and JP Nadda and other members in the Rajya Sabha during the second part of the Budget session of Parliament in New Delhi

2026, requesting that an all-party meeting chaired by the PM be convened at the earliest to discuss, as desired by you, the modalities and roadmap for the implementation of the Nari Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023,” read the letter written on Congress president Kharge’s letterhead. The letter has signatories from several Opposition parties, except the Trinamool Congress.

This comes after the Government said it was planning to bring two bills in the ongoing Budget session of Parliament to ensure that the women’s reservation law is implemented before the completion of the delimitation exercise for the Lok Sabha and assembly constituencies.

The Opposition leaders, in their letter, said that the

Government was planning a further amendment to the Nari Shakti Vandan Bill passed in September 2023. The law is officially known as the Constitution (106th Amendment) Act.

“All Opposition parties now reiterate their demand for an all-party meeting to discuss the proposed Constitution Amendment. To make the meeting more productive, it is necessary for the Government to circulate a note detailing what exactly is being proposed.

“The all-party meeting should be held after the current round of assembly elections is completed on April 29, 2026,” the letter read. Congress leader Jairam Ramesh handed over the letter to Rijiju after meeting him in Parliament House.

US calls India indispensable partner in shaping Indo-Pacific balance

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The United States has underscored India’s growing strategic importance in the Indo-Pacific, with Elbridge Colby describing India as an “essential partner” in maintaining regional stability during remarks at the Ananta Centre.

Speaking on his first official visit to India, Colby outlined Washington’s evolving defense and geopolitical framework toward New Delhi, emphasizing a pragmatic, interest-driven partnership rooted in shared concerns over the balance of power in Asia.

Colby highlighted that the Indo-Pacific has emerged as the central arena of global politics and economics, with both U.S. and Indian prosperity closely tied to developments in the region. He noted that no single nation can ensure stability alone, calling instead for “collective contributions of capable states.”

Within this framework, India’s geographic position, military capabilities, and economic rise make it a pivotal actor. “India’s role is indispensable,” Colby said, pointing to its location along critical Indian Ocean trade routes and its tradition of strategic autonomy.

A key theme of the

address was the alignment between Washington’s “flexible realism” and India’s foreign policy doctrine articulated by Subrahmanyam Jaishankar. Colby drew parallels between US interest-based strategy and India’s “Bharat First” approach, both of which prioritise national interests and pragmatic decision-making.

He argued that such



realism strengthens cooperation rather than limiting it, even when disagreements arise. “We do not expect nor require unerring agreement,” Colby said, adding that flexibility and mutual respect are central to long-term collaboration.

The speech highlighted rapid progress in US-India defense ties, including expanded military exercises, intelligence sharing, and technology collaboration. Colby referenced a recent defense framework agreement signed with Rajesh

Kumar Singh, aimed at accelerating joint capabilities.

Priority areas for cooperation include maritime security, anti-submarine warfare, long-range precision systems, and resilient logistics — capabilities seen as critical in the Indo-Pacific security environment.

Colby also emphasised growing opportunities for defense industrial collabora-

Nation Focus



Nitish Kumar elected JD(U) president unopposed

Bihar CM Nitish Kumar was elected JD (U) president unopposed on Tuesday with no other candidate filing nomination for the party’s top post.

The Bihar CM has been serving as the party’s president since Lalan Singh resigned from the post ahead of the Lok Sabha polls in December 2023. Kumar (75) was elected to the Rajya Sabha in elections held recently. Returning officer Aneel Prasad Hegde, a former Rajya Sabha MP, announced Kumar’s election as the JD (U) chief and handed over the certificate of his election to the party’s working president Sanjay Kumar Jha and Union minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh alias Lalan Singh at the party’s central office here.



Gujarat tables UCC Bill for marriage, succession, live-ins

The Gujarat Government on Tuesday tabled the Gujarat Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill, 2026, in the Legislative Assembly, proposing a common legal framework to govern marriage, divorce, succession and live-in relationships irrespective of religion.

The Bill was tabled by Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, a week after a State-appointed panel submitted its final report on the implementation of the UCC. If the Bill is cleared, Gujarat will become the second State in the country after Uttarakhand to pass a UCC bill. Uttarakhand, in February 2024, passed a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill.

Rajnath Singh reviews security situation amid West Asia conflict

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Tuesday reviewed the security situation with top officials, including the Services chiefs, in the backdrop of the ongoing West Asia conflict and its effect on India’s defence preparedness. The war has entered its fourth week, disrupting trade routes

through the Strait of Hormuz. Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan, Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh, Army Chief General Upendra Dwivedi, and Navy Chief Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi attended the meeting. Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, Secretary of the Department of Defence Research and Development (DDR&D) and



Chairman of the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) Samir Kamat, and Secretary of the Department of Defence Production Sanjeev Kumar were also present, Defence Ministry said.

Giving details, officials said the defence minister was briefed about the global and regional security scenario, the impact of a possible esca-

lation of the ongoing conflicts on India as well as the challenges and opportunities presented by the current geopolitical situation.

The impact of the situation on the supply chain management towards procurement and production of defence equipment, including maintenance and serviceability of existing equipment, was also examined.



Narendra Modi
Hon'ble Prime Minister



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States Focus



BJP URGES ROLLBACK OF ₹5 FUEL CESS IN HIMACHAL

The BJP on Tuesday asked the Congress Government in Himachal Pradesh to roll back the ₹5 cess on fuel, calling the measure “anti-common man”, and alleged that it will extract over ₹1,000 crore annually from the public through increased VAT and the additional cess. Referring to the Congress’ pre-poll promises of financial doles, the saffron party also attacked Rahul Gandhi, saying his “khatakhata model” of governance has burdened the common people with repeated tax hikes. The party claimed the new cess will directly impact every household already struggling with rising costs.



CM NAIDU VOWS TAP WATER TO EVERY HOME IN 2 YEARS

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday said that every house in the State will be supplied with tapped drinking water under the Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0 by 2028. The chief minister noted that the Government is working under the ‘Har Ghar Jal’ programme to provide safe drinking water to every village and every home. “Under Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0, we will fulfil the goal of providing tapped drinking water to every house by 2028,” Naidu said in an official release.

The cat is out of the bag: Mamata on BJP stamp row

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Tuesday alleged that the purported BJP rubber stamp on a communication of the Election Commission of India (ECI) proved beyond doubt which party was controlling the poll watchdog from backseat.

A political row erupted on Monday after a March 2019 letter from the ECI was found carrying the seal of the BJP’s Kerala unit. “It is now clear from this BJP rubber stamp on ECI notification who is running the commission from behind. The cat is out of the bag,” Banerjee told reporters at the Kolkata airport before boarding a flight to Bagdogra in north Bengal, where she is scheduled to commence election campaigns. She held up a newspaper report on the row to back her claims of the poll panel’s “lack of neutrality” in conducting the assembly elections.

“There’s no need to play your games from behind the curtains. Come out in the open and fight us face to face,” the CM said, without naming the commission. Banerjee alleged that the ECI’s move to transfer the Nandigram BDO — an officer she indirectly claimed was close to Suwendu Adhikari — to Bhabanipur, the seat where the BJP leader would take on Banerjee in the upcoming polls, reeked of a political conspiracy. “On Monday, the ECI reshuffled 73 returning officers of the State. Earlier, they transferred out some 70 top IAS and IPS officers of Bengal, including the chief secretary, home secretary, the DGP and Kolkata CP. And now we know which party is pulling strings from behind,” she said.

“This is not a clerical mistake, it was done with a deliberate political intention,” Banerjee claimed, refuting the ECI’s reported response that it was a human error. She claimed that the ECI communication was not meant only for Kerala but was addressed to the chief elec-

toral officers of all States and union territories. Alleging that the development put a serious question mark on the poll panel’s impartiality in conducting the elections, Banerjee urged all parties to unite and fight the “attempt to impose one-party rule in India”.

“It doesn’t matter if Opposition parties belong to the Right or Left ideologies. I request them to come together and fight against the dictatorship, autocracy and protest the one-party rule of the Government and its agencies. I urge them to protest in the country’s interest and ensure free and fair polls,” she said, adding her call was not to elicit support but to “save democracy”.

Reacting to Banerjee’s comments, CPI(M) central committee member Suján Chakraborty said, “When the TMC leaders frequently claim that we have become zero in Bengal, why is their supremo seeking our support? We have always been at the forefront in the fight against



West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee

tions. As per the ECI website, the nomination of Congress candidates Ananda Narah from the Dhakuakhana seat, Nirmal Langthasa from Haflong and Bidisha Neog from Jalukbari have been rejected.

The Dhakuakhana seat is currently held by former minister Naba Kumar Doley of the BJP. For Haflong, BJP cabinet minister Nandita Garlosa’s candidature as Congress nominee has been accepted. Garlosa

had joined the Opposition party on Sunday night and filed her nomination papers the very next day.

The reasons for the rejection have not been cited on the ECI website. Among others whose nominations have been rejected so far are three candidates each of Jharkhand Mukti Morcha and Voters Party International, one each of SUCI (Communist) and Apni Janta Party, and eight Independents.

lacks transparency. Else, why had they taken so long to put the list out when the judicial officers completed the task of finalising the (first supplementary) rolls almost a week ago? Have you deleted more names? Have you unilaterally added names for a particular political party? We will get a clearer picture of that once the full list is published,” the CM said. Around 60 lakh names were marked as “under adjudication” in the post-SIR electoral rolls published on February 28.

The supplementary list contains the names of around 29 lakh voters whose cases have been adjudicated by the judicial officers, according to the Election Commission. BJP MLA Sankar Ghosh accused the CM of attempting to stall the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls and spreading misinformation about the exercise.

“I don’t want to comment on the statement of the CM who frequently makes false, illogical statements even on the floor of the assembly,” Ghosh, the BJP chief whip, alleged.

In Assam CM’s seat, nomination of Congress candidates, 2 others rejected

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The nomination of three Congress candidates, including that of the Jalukbari seat where Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma is contesting for the Assam assembly elections, have been rejected during scrutiny on Tuesday, according to the Election Commission. Altogether 18 nomination papers have been cancelled till 4.30 pm. The process of scrutinising nomination papers,



CM Himanta Biswa Sarma starting 2nd leg of Assam BJP’s Jana Ashirvada Yatra from his home constituency Jalukbari, Guwahati

however, is not yet complete.

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ED detects ₹35,925 crore in 257 cybercrime cases

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) identified proceeds of crime worth ₹35,925.58 crore in 257 cybercrime cases it undertook till February 28, the Lok Sabha was informed on Tuesday.

In a written reply, Minister of State for Home Affairs, Bandi Sanjay Kumar, said that under an established mechanism, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) and the law enforcement agencies share information, including matters related to cyber-crime, through their respective nodal officers.



“In addition, the ED shares information with other agencies under Section 66(2) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), whenever a contravention pertaining to the relevant agency is noticed during investigation under the Act,” Kumar said.

The minister said the ED is also using SHAHYOG, Samanvaya and the cyber police portal maintained by the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) under the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA).

The Samanvaya platform serves as a management information system (MIS), data repository, and coordination platform for the law enforcement agencies for cybercrime data sharing and analytics, Kumar said.

It provides analytics-based inter-State linkages of crimes and criminals involved in cybercrime complaints in various States/UTs, he added.

“The ED also uses the Inter-operable Criminal Justice System (ICJS) portal to access cybercrime-related FIRs registered by various State police forces,” the minister said.

Security raised across tourist hot spots in Jammu & Kashmir

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

A day after the Union Home Secretary, Govind Mohan, directed the security agencies to beef up security measures of all the tourist hot spots, the Jammu and Kashmir police have initiated a fresh security audit to prevent a repeat of the Pahalgam-like terror attack in the region.

Ahead of the peak tourist season, Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha had ordered the immediate reopening of 14 major tourist destinations in February 2026.

The decision was taken after a comprehensive security review and discussion with various security agencies.

The tourist spots were closed down as precautionary measures in the aftermath of the horrific killing of 26 civil-



ians, 25 of whom were tourists, on April 22, 2025, in the Baisaran valley of Pahalgam.

Meanwhile, chairing a high-level security review meeting via video conferencing, the Union Home Secretary on Monday reviewed the overall security situation in the Union Territory with a specific focus on the fresh audit of the tourist hot spots in the wake of a surge in tourist footfalls.

So far, around one lakh tourists have visited Asia’s largest Tulip garden in Srinagar, and the numbers are expected to increase as the garden is in full bloom.

This year, around 18 lakh tulips of over 70 varieties, along with nearly one lakh other bulbous flowers including daffodils, hyacinths and narcissus, have been planted, adding vibrant colours to the

valley’s spring landscape.

Jammu region is also witnessing a rush of pilgrims headed to the Katra base camp to perform darshan inside the cave shrine of Mata Vaishno Devi. An average of 30,000 pilgrims are reaching Katra via different routes amid tight security arrangements.

In Srinagar, Director Floriculture Kashmir Mathoor Masoom Tuesday said that the Tulip Garden has witnessed a steady increase in visitor footfall since it was opened to the public on March 16.

“Both local visitors and tourists from outside are coming in large numbers. Many people try to enter the garden even during evening hours, though it remains open during fixed timings and the ticket counter closes accordingly,” she said.

Vaishnaw announces new refund rules for train tickets



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian Railways on Tuesday said there will be no refund for cancellation of train tickets up to eight hours before departure, instead of the existing norm of four hours.

Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the new refund rule will come into effect anytime from first fortnight of April. While announcing reforms in the railways sector, Vaishnaw other refund slabs have also been revised:

While a cancellation between 24 and eight hours will incur a 50 per cent deduction from the ticket cost against the existing 12 to four hours, similarly, the railways will deduct 25 per cent of the ticket cost for cancellation between 72 and 24 hours before departure.

A full refund — except a flat cancellation charge per passenger — will be given for cancellations made more than 72 hours before the train’s departure.

No data on hate speech against Northeast resident: Government

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

No centralised data is maintained on incidents of “hate speech, racial slurs, harassment and discrimination” against people from the Northeast, the Government said on Tuesday, while stressing that policing and public order fall under the domain of State Governments.

Responding to a question by Congress MP Gaurav Gogoi in the Lok Sabha, Minister of State for Home Nityanand Rai said States are responsible for prevention, detection, registration and investigation of crimes, and prosecution of offenders.

“Police and Public Order” are State subjects as per the Seventh Schedule to the Constitution of India. The State Governments are responsible for prevention, detection, registration and investigation of crime and for prosecuting the criminals through their law enforcement agencies,” Rai said.



He said the National Crime Records Bureau compiles and publishes crime data received from States and Union territories in its “Crime in India” reports, which are available till 2023.

However, “data on incidents of hate speech, racial slurs, harassment and discrimination against persons from the North-Eastern States is not maintained centrally,” the minister said. He added that existing legal provisions enable action against hate comments, gestures and racial acts, including those targeting people from the Northeast.

Rai also outlined steps taken by the Ministry of Home Affairs to address concerns related to safety and discrimination. These include advisories to States and UTs, appointment of nodal officers to handle grievances, and sensitisation of law enforcement agencies.

CPI(M) slams Govt as ‘subordinate ally’ of US

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Tuesday adopted a stinging resolution at its ‘Jan Aakrosh Rally’ at Ramlila Maidan, accusing the BJP-led Union Government of becoming a “subordinate ally” of the United States and failing to protect citizens from the economic fallout of the ongoing West Asia conflict.

Releasing the resolution on behalf of the CPI(M) Central Committee, Muralidharan stated that the US-Israel attacks on Iran and Palestine have triggered a severe domestic crisis. The party flagged an acute scarcity of gas cylinders reaching rural pockets and



CPI(M) General Secretary MA Baby, party leader Brinda Karat and other leaders during the ‘Jan Aakrosh Rally’ against the India-US trade deal and various Government policies at Ramlila Maidan in New Delhi

slammed the Government for recent hikes in petrol and LPG prices, which have driven up the cost of essential commodities like rice and vegetables.

The resolution condemned the “genocidal” nature of the aggression in



rooms in health centres, additional classrooms, Anganwadi centres, hostels, dormitories in schools, and livelihood projects.

The minister said the Border Area Development Programme (BADP) is imple-

39,000 projects approved under border development programme since 2004

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 39,000 projects have been approved under the Border Area Development Programme, which is in its ‘sunset phase’, since FY 2004-05 in the bordering States and UTs, including Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and Jammu and Kashmir, the Lok Sabha was informed on Tuesday.

In a written reply, Minister of State for Home Affairs, Nityanand Rai, said these projects include the construction of roads, FSB, bridges and culverts, residential quarters for doctors, paramedics and other health officials, additional

Gaza and Iran, specifically highlighting a school strike that claimed the lives of over 160 girl students and teachers. It further noted with alarm the kidnapping of Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro, the bombing of an Iranian vessel

participating in Indian Navy events, and the intensified blockade against Cuba.

“Instead of condemning these inhuman attacks, the BJP Government has stood with the US and Israel,” the resolution noted, adding that India’s strategic autonomy has been compromised. The CPI(M) demanded that the Union Government immediately issue a formal condemnation of the military actions and take proactive steps to ensure the safety of Indians residing in the Gulf and West Asia. The party also called for an immediate end to the war and urged the Centre to curb spiralling inflation and ensure the unhindered supply of cooking gas to the poor.

Sewer deaths: Sanitation workers to hold protest at Jantar Mantar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Safai Karmachari Andolan (SKA) will organise a massive protest demonstration and dharna at Jantar Mantar on Wednesday to demand an immediate end to the “killings” of workers in sewers and septic tanks across the country.

The protest will see the participation of safai karmacharis from 10 States, activists, and the families of those who have lost their lives in the line of duty. A formal letter of demands addressed to the Prime Minister will be released during the pro-

gramme, calling for urgent State intervention.

National Convenor of the SKA, Bezwada Wilson, expressed deep anguish over the Government’s perceived silence on the issue. “With deep pain, we State that one person is killed every second day in sewers and septic tanks in this country, but the Government is completely silent over this,” Wilson said.

The SKA alleged a significant discrepancy between official figures and ground reality. According to the organisation, the Government has consistently “manipulated and minimised” death data. For the year 2025, the SKA recorded 121 deaths in sewers



and septic tanks, while Government figures reported only 46. Similar gaps were noted for 2024, where the SKA recorded 116 deaths against the official report of 55. “The year 2026 has just started, and there have been 41 deaths

already - 41 killings in three months,” Wilson noted, adding that the Prime Minister should acknowledge this failure and issue a national apology.

Beyond sewer deaths, the SKA highlighted the persis-

tence of illegal manual scavenging in dry latrines across Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Bihar, and Jammu and Kashmir. The organisation slammed “false claims” made by ministers in Parliament regarding the elimination of the practice, calling it a denial of the lived realities of Dalit communities, especially women.

The SKA, which has been campaigning against the atrocity for 40 years, stated that the protest aims to challenge the claims of development and economic growth while the most marginalised continue to face “dehumanising” conditions.



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Delhi HC dismisses Lalu Yadav's plea to quash CBI FIR in land-for-jobs case



In a setback to Lalu Prasad Yadav, the Delhi High Court on Tuesday refused to quash a CBI FIR in the land-for-jobs case involving him and his family, rejecting the RJD supreme's contention that it was unsustainable under Section 17A of the Prevention of Corruption Act that was introduced in 2018, whereas the allegations date back to 2004-2009.

Justice Ravinder Dubeja dismissed the petition by Yadav, a former Railway Minister and ex-Chief Minister of Bihar, that also sought quashing of the three chargesheets filed in 2022, 2023 and 2024, and the subsequent orders of cognisance in the matter.

The 'land-for-jobs' case is related to Group D appointments made in the West Central Zone of the Indian Railways in Jabalpur, Madhya Pradesh, during Yadav's tenure as the Railways Minister between 2004 and 2009, allegedly in return for land parcels gifted or transferred by the recruits in the name of the RJD supreme's family or associates, said CBI.

SC Collegium clears proposal for appointment of 8 additional judges as permanent

The Supreme Court collegium on Tuesday approved a proposal for appointment of eight additional judges as permanent judges of two high courts. The collegium headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant in a meeting approved names of Justices R Poornima, M Jothiraman, and Augustine Devadoss Maria Cleto as permanent judges in the Madras High Court.

In another decision, the collegium has approved the names of Justices Sachin Singh Rajput, Radhakishan Agrawal, Sanjay Kumar Jaiswal, Bibhu Datta Guru, and Amitendra Kishore Prasad as permanent judges in the Chhattisgarh High Court.

University can't restrict peaceful expression of ideas that don't align with management's ideology: Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has revoked the suspension of a student of Dr BR Ambedkar University over alleged participation in a protest, observing that speech and peaceful expression of ideas cannot be restricted merely because they do not align with the ideology of the management.

Justice Jasmeet Singh emphasised that a university must create an atmosphere where students feel free to participate in discussions on academic or public issues and peaceful protests and non-violent dissent are a natural part of such an environment.

Justice Singh said a university that accepts only obedience fails in its broader educational role as it is not just a place where students attend classes and complete courses but also where they are expected to learn and inculcate independent



thought processes, the ability to ask questions, and engage in critical thinking.

"A school/ university is an instrumentality of the State and carries out an indispensable public function, that is, shaping the makers of tomorrow. The University cannot restrict speech and peaceful expression of ideas, merely because the views expressed by a group of students do not align with the ideology of the management," said the court in an order passed on March 13. "When students express disagreement in a peaceful and orderly manner, without



Anil Ambani writes to FM seeking Sandesara kind settlement package

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Debt ridden industrialist Anil Ambani sought Sandesara kind hair cut package and cancellation of all cases from Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman. According to Anil Ambani's supplementary counter affidavit filed to Supreme Court on Monday, he had written to Finance Minister on March 19. He also marked the letter's copy to SBI and Bank of Baroda heads.

"The precedent set by the Supreme Court itself in the Sterling Biotech/Sandesara matter — where the court approved a full and final settlement for a family of declared fugitive economic offenders who had fled India, closing all FIRs and CBI proceedings, withdrawing Interpol Red Corner Notices, releasing attached properties, and absolving liability of seven individuals and seven companies — upon a one-time settlement of ₹5,100 crore.

"I have not been declared a fugitive. To the contrary, I have given an undertaking to this Hon'ble Court that I will not leave the country without its permission," argued Anil Ambani seeking Sandesara



Anil Ambani and Nirmala Sitharaman

kind package. Anil Ambani said If a structured resolution was achievable for individuals outside India's jurisdiction who had been declared fugitives, it is both pragmatically and legally possible in his case — where he has remained in India, cooperated with courts, and actively supported insolvency proceedings. He describes himself as "the first and only promoter in India to actively support the CIRP process" for Reliance Capital.

Anil Ambani said Supreme Court cancelling telecom license had collapsed his telecom business, like Videocon and Aircel. Collapse of IL & FS frozen liquidity of

many finance company including Reliance Capital, which was once a top-end AAA credit rating until October 2018; it defaulted only in October 2019 as a direct consequence of the IL&FS-triggered; liquidity mis-match, argued the industrialist, narrating his companies' crisis.

The Reliance Group has also been under CBI and Enforcement Directorate scrutiny for nearly ten months, resulting in the provisional attachment of over ₹15,000 crore in group assets — described as the largest single attachment in the Enforcement Directorate's history. The document States

this has resulted in a loss of over ₹25,000 crore in market value, directly affecting over 50 lakh small retail shareholders said the affidavit citing the letter to Finance Minister Sitharaman and heads of SBI and Bank of Baroda.

On Monday appearing for Anil Ambani, Advocate Mukul Rohatgi said that due to the Public Interest Litigation filed former Government Secretary ESA Sarma, represented by Prashant Bhushan, no bankers are not taking to him, though he wanted to have negotiation to settle the dues.

In November 2025, The bench headed by Justices JK Maheswari and Vijay Bishnoi approved the proposal given Government in sealed cover to give One Time Settlement of Sandesara Group. As per the settlement, all criminal cases against fugitives Nitin and Chetan Sandesaras will be withdrawn and return the attached properties by ED. The OTS allowed was for ₹ 5,100 crore, while the Group was facing bank dues of more than ₹19,000 crore. ED has attached their ₹13,000 crore worth assets and they were facing cases for bribery, perjury and creation of fake Albanian passport to flee country along with family.

Delhi court sentences Kashmiri separatist Asiya Andrabi to life imprisonment in UAPA case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Tuesday sentenced Kashmiri separatist and Dukhtaran-e-Millat chief Asiya Andrabi to life imprisonment for conspiring to commit a crime against the State. Additional Sessions Judge Chander Jit Singh also sentenced Andrabi's two associates, Sofi Fehmeeda and Nahida Nasreen, to 30 years' imprisonment in the case.

The court awarded life sentences to Andrabi under Section 18 (punishment for conspiracy) of the stringent Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and under Sections 120B (criminal conspiracy) and 121 A of the erstwhile IPC. According to Section 16 of the UAPA, "Whoever commits a terrorist act shall, if such act has result-

ed in the death of any person, be punishable with death or imprisonment for life, and shall also be liable to fine."

Section 121 A deals with "conspiracy to commit offences punishable by section 121", while according to Section 121, "Whoever wages war against the Government of India, or attempts to wage such war, or abets the waging of such war, shall be punished with death, or imprisonment for life and shall also be liable to fine." The court, however, clarified that the sentences will run concurrently.

Fehmeeda and Nasreen were sentenced to 30 years of simple imprisonment under Section 18 of the UAPA and Section 120B of the IPC. The three had been sentenced on January 14, following which the National Investigation Agency (NIA) had sought life



Asiya Andrabi

imprisonment for Andrabi, saying she had waged war against India, and a stern message was required to be sent that conspiring against the State would invite the harshest penalty. In its 286-page order, the court had said that Andrabi and her associates hatched a conspiracy for the secession of Kashmir from India. It said the

videos submitted by the NIA clearly showed that they repeatedly claimed that Kashmir belonged to Pakistan and was under the forced occupation of India.

The order said, "That Kashmir should be freed from Indian occupation so that it can become part of Pakistan. The material on record is rife with such speeches as well as

various posts by all the accused, especially of accused 1 (Andrabi)." It said that Andrabi, in her speeches and interviews, clearly advocated and sought the support of Pakistan to claim and propagate that Kashmir was never a part of India.

"It is clear that the accused are not merely stating that Kashmir is an unfinished agenda of Partition rather the above discussion clearly spells out that this aspect is misused by accused persons to support, endorse and propagate that Kashmir is not a part of India," the court's order said. It had been observed that the 'Dukhtaran-E-Millat' (DeM), an organisation founded by Andrabi, was involved in activities related to the secession of an integral part of India from India on the "pretext of claim of right to self-determination".

"To further these activities, various speeches were made as well as interviews given. There are multiple posts as discussed in preceding paragraphs mentioning the fact of organising/ convening by accused persons to encourage and support this aim," said the court, adding that "the accused have attempted to create a facade that Kashmir is not part of India and is under illegal Indian occupation," the court had said. It also said that the accused pushed a narrative to promote that the partition between the two countries, India and Pakistan, was premised on the two-nation theory based on religious background.

Andrabi and her two associates were formally charged with multiple offences under UAPA and the IPC in February 2021.

I-PAC raids: SC quizzes Bengal Govt, says ED officers also have fundamental rights

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday quizzed the West Bengal Government over its objection to the maintainability of the Enforcement Directorate's plea on the alleged obstruction by Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee during a raid, asking about the fundamental rights of ED officers.

The top court remarked that some officers of the ED have filed petitions in their individual capacity seeking to know whether they cease to be citizens of India merely because they are officers of the agency.

The West Bengal Government has questioned the maintainability of the ED's plea which alleged obstruction by Banerjee and other state authorities during its January 8 search of the office of political consultancy firm Indian Political Action



Committee's (I-PAC) in Kolkata. The search was in connection with a money-laundering probe.

A bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and N V Anjaria was told by senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Banerjee, that a person who moves the court under Article 32 of the Constitution has to specifically set out which fundamental right of his has been violated. "Please concentrate on the fundamental rights of the officers of the ED with whom the offence has been committed. If you only con-

centrate on ED, ED, ED and forget the second petition which is preferred by the individual officers who were the victims of that offence, you may miss the point and you will be in difficulty," Justice Mishra observed.

Sibal argued that the person (Deputy Director Robin Bansal) who filed the writ petition has not claimed a violation of any fundamental right.

"Not only that, assuming he has a fundamental right, then the petition must state which fundamental right has been violated," he said

adding that in this particular case the ED is not even a person.

Sibal said any obstruction in the performance of a statutory duty is not a violation of a fundamental right.

"If someone obstructs a police officer, he can't file a petition under Article 32. He also can't file a 226 petition. There will be a prosecution launched for the obstruction of violating his right to discharge his functions," Sibal said.

At this juncture, Justice Mishra remarked, "If the CM barges into an ED investigation and commits an offence, your idea of remedy for the ED is to go to the state Government which is headed by the CM and inform them about it and seek remedy?"

Responding to the question, Sibal said, "Your lordships are assuming that the chief minister has committed an offence."

Delhi HC sets aside conviction of Sonu Punjaban in trafficking case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday set aside the conviction and 24-year jail sentence of Geeta Arora alias Sonu Punjaban in a case of alleged trafficking of a 12-year-old girl and acquitted her of all charges. Justice Chandrasekharan Sudha also granted the relief to co-accused Sandeep Bedwal who was sentenced to 20 years in jail in the case probed by the Delhi Police.

The court, in its judgement on appeals by the two accused, said the testimony of victim suffered from "material contradictions,

improvements and inconsistencies" and her conduct cast a "serious shadow" on her reliability.

The court held that there were "several gaps in the prosecution story" and in the absence of any independent corroboration, it was unsafe to sustain the conviction of the appellants on the basis of the victim's testimony.

"In these circumstances, it can only be held that the materials on record are insufficient to find A1 and A2 guilty of the offences charged against them. Therefore, the conclusion can only be that the trial court went wrong in relying on such unsatisfacto-



Sonu Punjaban

ry evidence to find the guilt of the accused," the court held. "In the result, the appeals are allowed and the impugned judgment of conviction and order on sentence are set aside. The appellants, namely, A1 is

acquitted under Section 235(1) CrPC of the charges under Sections 363, 366, 366A, 370, 372, 376, and 120B. A2 is acquitted under Section 235(1) CrPC of the charges under Sections 366A, 370, 372, 373, 328, 342 and 120B

IPC. They are set at liberty and their respective bail bonds shall stand cancelled," the court concluded.

As per the prosecution, the victim, "who was about 12 years, was kidnapped in 2009. It was alleged that Bedwal had enticed her under the pretext of marriage, raped her and then sold to several persons who forced her into prostitution and sexually exploited her.

During the course of such trafficking, the victim was ultimately sold to Sonu Punjaban, who used her for prostitution before further selling her to other persons, it was claimed.

In the judgement, the

court opined that the investigation in the present case suffered from serious deficiencies as the persons allegedly involved in the chain of trafficking were neither properly identified nor apprehended.

It observed that the prosecution did not establish any "definite or consistent timeline" of when the victim was in Sonu Punjaban's custody.

The prosecution having failed to establish a clear and cogent timeline linking Sonu Punjaban with the alleged acts, the benefit of such doubt must necessarily enure to the appellant, the court stated.



Municipal Corporation
Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

Phone No.(0240) 2333336-40, 2348001-05 (PBX) Fax No.(0240) 2331213

No./CSMC/BOT/103/2026 Date: 24/3/2026

CORRIGENDUM

Reference:- No./BOT/CSMC/2026/90, dated: 02/03/2026

Tender notice for Development of Commercial Complex (Shops & Offices), Banquet / Exhibition Hall on Build Operate and Transfer Basis situated at CTS No.3208, Nehru Bhavan, Buddilane, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar Municipal Corporation, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar.

Tender ID: 2026-AMCA-1283163-1 Published in daily newspapers and also on www.mahatenders.gov.in. As per the above reference Schedule of bid opening process of last date of submission 25/03/2026 is changed and extended to 05/04/2026 up to 16.00 hrs is considered. Schedule of Opening of Technical Bid and for further Details will be published on www.mahatenders.gov.in portal. Rest of the conditions remains unchanged.

Commissioner
Municipal Corporation,
Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

Advt. : 2026/105
Date : 24/03/2026

Editor's
TAKE

India-Bangladesh ties: Eid
diplomacy signals a thaw

A warm exchange between Narendra Modi and Tarique Rahman, and Rahman's acceptance of an India invite, signals a tentative thaw in bilateral ties

India and Bangladesh, after months of diplomatic chill, are now once again trying to come closer and bury the hatchet. After Sheikh Hasina's ouster and her taking shelter in India, public sentiment in Bangladesh was negative about India, to say the least. But full marks to PM Modi for greeting 'Eid Mubarak' to Prime Minister Tarique Rahman and inviting him to India. The invitation has been readily accepted by him, which shows that the two nations have made up their minds to leave the past behind and build relations despite Sheikh Hasina's pending extradition to Bangladesh. This outreach goes beyond ceremonial warmth; it reflects a will to reset relations, which are hurting both sides. India and Bangladesh share a unique relationship rooted in history, geography, and culture. The ties grew stronger with connectivity, trade, and security cooperation, though not without irritants, such as border management and water issues, which derailed relations many times. A large section of Bangladesh has seen India as a big brother trying to dominate it and meddle in its affairs. This became pronounced during the Gen Z uprising, when anti-India sentiment reached a crescendo. However, after the elections and with a mature and pragmatic government in Dhaka, things can certainly become better. Tarique Rahman, with a strong mandate, can take unpopular decisions which would be good for Bangladesh in the long run. His early communication to Modi underscores three things: recognition of shared historical bonds, a focus on delivering tangible benefits to citizens, and a commitment to advancing ties based on equality, dignity, and mutual respect. Notably, his reference to India's "Viksit Bharat 2047" vision suggests a willingness to align Bangladesh's developmental aspirations with India's long-term regional outlook. Indeed, there are challenges that the new government will have to take into account—Bangladesh's economy faces headwinds from global uncertainties, export dependencies, and energy vulnerabilities. India has long supported Bangladesh with infrastructure and energy projects, and this cooperation can be further strengthened, keeping in mind that Bangladesh is facing a tough time as it works to set its house in order. For long, India has been keen to keep its next-door neighbours happy and build good relations with them, which are mutually beneficial and help each other in times of natural calamities, pandemics, and economic crises. Bangladesh fits perfectly into India's "Neighbourhood First" policy. Enhanced cooperation with Dhaka facilitates connectivity to the Northeast, strengthens regional supply chains, and, above all, helps keep Chinese influence at bay. However, the two leaders will have to tread cautiously, as domestic political narratives in both countries are not conducive and can derail progress. The need of the hour is that both countries must resolve pending issues like water-sharing and cross-border migration. Rahman's visit could go a long way in building lasting relations with Bangladesh.

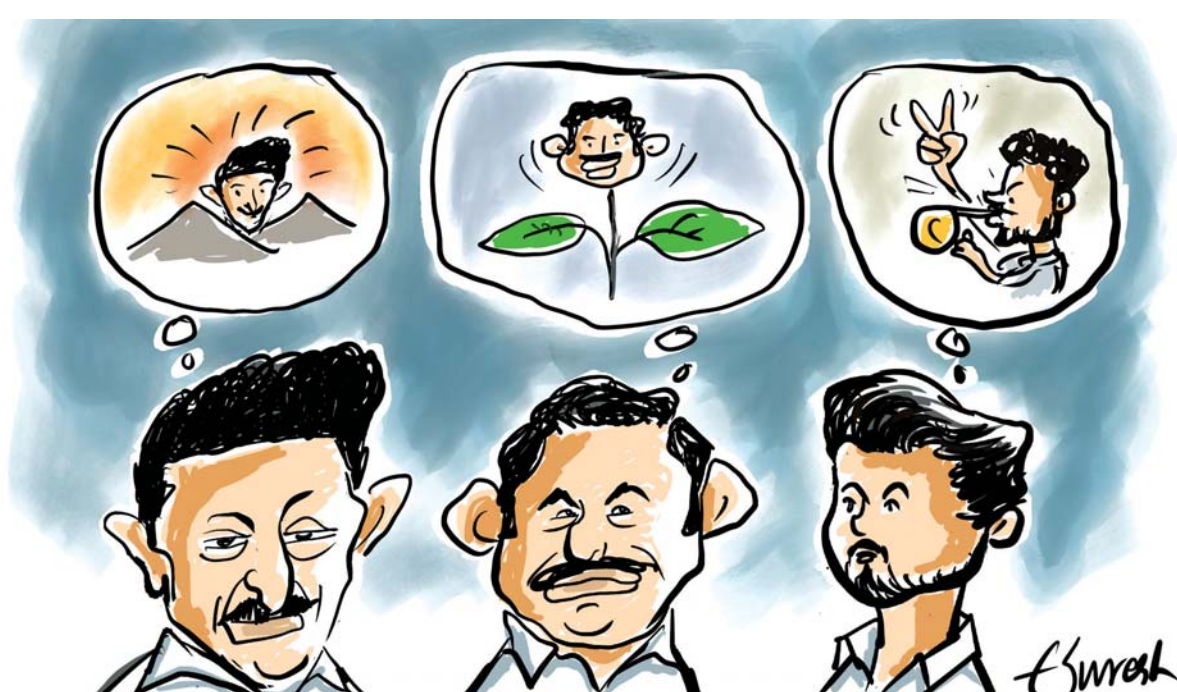
Tamil Nadu polls: Three-way battle on the cards

With over six crore voters set to decide the outcome, the election is as much about leadership and alliances as it is about whether Tamil Nadu is ready to move beyond its Dravidian duopoly



KALYANI SHANKAR

Tamil Nadu is poised for a competitive three-way contest in the upcoming Assembly elections scheduled for April 23. This election has significant implications for the state and its leaders. The ruling DMK aims to make history by securing a second consecutive term in power. Meanwhile, the AIADMK, the main opposition party, is working to restore its former prominence and regain control. The BJP, which has been trying to perform well, is aligning itself with the AIADMK. Meanwhile, Vijay's new political venture is emerging as a significant force in the region. The AIADMK's influence in Tamil Nadu has weakened without a charismatic leader like Jayalalithaa. About 70 per cent of the population belongs to Other Backward Classes (OBC), with key communities such as the Gounders, Thevars, and Vanniyars impacting elections. Voter awareness among these groups is essential, especially with the internal divisions among the Thevars and the rise of new parties like the Tamil Valvur Katchi (TVK). In the upcoming elections, about 6.17 crore eligible voters will decide the outcome. This election is particularly significant because of the emergence of film star Vijay's new party, dubbed the "X factor", though its influence remains uncertain. For decades, Tamil Nadu's political scene has been dominated by bipolar politics, primarily represented by the DMK and AIADMK. A victory for Chief Minister Stalin would establish him as one of Tamil Nadu's most significant leaders, being the first DMK Chief Minister to serve a full five-year term and return to power. For E Palaniswamy, this election is crucial for his political survival after defeats since J Jayalalithaa's death. The RSS-BJP coalition has leveraged its financial resources and media presence to suggest they can win. Key issues like rising crimes against women, unfulfilled campaign promises, and the debt crisis are expected to dominate the election. The DMK alliance's careful expansion and new programmes aim to boost voter confidence, demonstrating that strategic planning can drive positive change. At the start of a new term, a ruling party often struggles with a leader who remains respected but a fatigued team. This situation emphasises the need for generational change within the DMK. Senior ministers are reluctant



POLITICAL PARTIES IN THE STATE ARE OFFERING INCENTIVES SUCH AS CASH TRANSFERS AND EXPANDED WELFARE PROGRAMMES TO ATTRACT WOMEN VOTERS, A CRUCIAL DEMOGRAPHIC THEY CANNOT AFFORD TO IGNORE

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to retire and want to secure positions for their successors. Retaining too many long-serving members could alienate local voters, while pushing them out risks internal conflict before the elections. The Congress party has not regained power since 1967 and relies on the Dravidian party's support. Recently, it won 28 seats and a Rajya Sabha berth, but the DMK rejected its power-sharing request. The CPI, CPI(M), VCK, and other groups are also negotiating their allocations. Overall, their position appears strong. The NDA's chances of ruling appear weak despite the BJP's support. Iconic leaders like MG Ramachandran, M Karunanidhi, and J Jayalalithaa have traditionally driven Tamil Nadu's politics. Currently, the state lacks a strong leader, and Vijay could effectively fill this role. The Opposition believes the DMK should be vulnerable after five years, but that does not guarantee a power shift. Analysts highlight that public dissatisfaction alone will not necessarily help the AIADMK regain power. Edappadi K. Palaniswami aims to show the alliance's stability and refute rumours of conflict with BJP leaders. The key challenge is whether voters see the AIADMK as a viable alternative rather than just an anti-DMK platform. Vijay sees the current situation as a chance to gain support from women and young voters. If the polls are accurate, this election could enhance his reputation for the 2029 elections. His two-year-old party aims to

attract the 18-30 age group, which comprises about 1.12 crore of the 5.67 crore total voters, as well as many minority voters due to his Christian faith. Vijay's party is causing uncertainty for established parties and pollsters. As a newcomer to Tamil Nadu politics, TVK has no polling history, and his party is untested. Vijay's entry is expected to affect the DMK by drawing votes from minorities and Dalits, who have supported the alliance since 2019. Reports suggest the BJP has offered him 80 seats and the Deputy Chief Minister position to join the NDA, but Vijay has reportedly turned it down. The key question is whether he can turn his fan base into votes, as MGR and NTR did. Smaller parties like Vaiko's Marumalarchi Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam, Dr S. Ramadoss' Pattali Makkal Katchi, and Seeman's Naam Tamilar Katchi have historically aligned with major Dravidian parties. Sasikala, a former associate of Jayalalithaa, has formed her own party but has yet to contest elections. Her alliance with S Ramadoss may affect youth and minority votes, complicating the electoral landscape. Political parties in the state are offering incentives such as cash transfers and expanded welfare programmes to attract women voters, a crucial demographic they cannot afford to ignore. Overall, despite the frictions within and across the lower castes, the ideological basis of the Dravidian movement continues and is further strengthened.



PIC TALK



A woman harvests wheat crop at a field in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh. PHOTO: PTI



SHANKAR SAHAY

2ND OPINION

Every day my return journey from the office brings me face to face with different experiences. While my car's driver meanders his way through the traffic, I sit in the back seat and gaze through the car window, soaking in various scenes previously unknown to my affluent self. On one such evening, as the car stopped at a traffic light, I observed some commotion on the footpath opposite my car. Since the windows were rolled up, I couldn't hear the voices, but the situation was obvious. A five-year-old child was bawling loudly, holding tightly to the handle of a tricycle and trying his best, which was not good enough, to prevent it from being taken away by a ten-year-old child. The five-year-old was being supported by an older girl, presumably his



elder sister, in fighting to clinch this prized possession. No prizes for guessing that the tricycle must have belonged to both of them, and the elder "bully", if you may call him so, was trying to take it away from them. All three of them were dressed in rags. The force being used by the eldest child to snatch the tricycle was directly proportional to the grip of the youngest child and his elder sibling. Neither of them was ready to give up. It was as if a tug of war was taking place right in front of my eyes, and all I could do was wait with bated breath for the result. Of course, I was hoping that the youngest child would get back his valuable gem. Well, I presumed it was his. There was an exchange of words which I could not hear, but this silent movie was very



much understandable even without the audio. The fight continued for over a minute, which was the time for which my car was standing at the traffic junction. Finally, the eldest child let the tricycle go. Immediately, the youngest child's weeping stopped. He wiped his tears and, holding his tricycle in one hand and the finger of his elder sister with the other, started crossing the road to the other side, presumably where his other family members were present. The bully child's words and even a kick on his buttocks were not important to him. He had been able to retain his treasure. The entire episode made me wonder about the lives of these children. At a tender age, when our children are safeguarded, these children learn to fight for their rights, knowing fully well that if they do not do it, then no one else will help them. While our ten-year-olds are bestowed with the best material products at their demand and at the click of a mobile phone key, these children's temptations get the better of them and train them to snatch something which is not rightfully theirs. As the traffic signal turned green, I thanked the Almighty for the blessed life He has given me and prayed for the well-being of all.

The writer is an educator author, and corporate coach

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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EDUCATION GROWING BUT JOBS
NOT GROWING EQUALLY

Recent Azim Premji University report confirms what many families already know firsthand. Degrees are increasing, but meaningful jobs are not growing at the same pace. Eleven million unemployed graduates are not just statistics; they represent a generation waiting for opportunities that are not arriving fast enough. The figures present a worrying picture. Nearly 40 per cent of graduates in the labour force face unemployment, a number that has changed very little in four decades. Male enrolment in higher education is also declining, as many young men leave studies early to support their families. This shows a growing loss of faith in the education-to-employment pathway, which is a serious warning sign. Two reforms are urgently

needed. Vocational training must lose its social stigma. ITIs have increased in number, but the quality of many private institutes has declined. Expansion without proper accountability is harmful. Similarly, private colleges with very high student-teacher ratios cannot be allowed to operate without strict regulation. The widening gap between poor and affluent students in professional education is another concern. Financial support through scholarships and affordable loans must be strengthened. India's demographic dividend will not last forever, and employment growth must keep pace with rising graduate numbers. Education and economic policy must work together, not separately.

SM JEEVA | CHENNAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

AI cannot deliver justice

The observation by the Apex Court's senior-most judge, Justice Vikram Nath, that artificial intelligence can assist but never replace judges in writing judgments is both timely and reassuring. In an era where AI is rapidly transforming various sectors, its role in the justice system must be carefully defined and understood. Artificial intelligence undoubtedly offers significant advantages. It can process vast amounts of legal data, assist in research, and provide quick summaries of complex cases. Such capabilities can improve efficiency and reduce the burden on courts. However, delivering justice goes far beyond data analysis and pattern recognition. Judicial decisions require an understanding of human behaviour, social context, and ethical considerations. Unlike algorithms, human judges can interpret nuances, assess intent, and balance the letter of the law with its spirit. Moreover, accountability remains a cornerstone of the justice system. A judgment must be delivered by a human authority who can be questioned, critiqued, and held responsible. AI, being a tool without consciousness or moral responsibility, cannot fulfil this role.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI

Cleaning Ganga still a challenge

The ongoing efforts to clean the Ganges are increasingly exposing serious gaps in planning and execution. For decades, multiple initiatives have been launched and massive funds allocated to make the river clean and uninterrupted in flow. However, the results have remained far from satisfactory. After the failure of the Ganga Action Plan, the Namami Gange Programme was introduced with renewed hope, yet it too has struggled due to administrative negligence and poor implementation. A recent report by the Comptroller and Auditor General of India has highlighted critical flaws such as poorly designed sewage treatment plants, unnecessary construction of cremation ghats, and rampant dumping of waste near smaller tributaries. These issues point to weak monitoring and lack of accountability. Cleaning the Ganges is not merely a matter of allocating funds; it requires sincere execution, accurate assessment of local needs, and strict accountability mechanisms. Without these, even large expenditures will continue to yield negligible outcomes, leaving the river polluted and the mission unfulfilled.

AMRIT LAL MARU | INDORE

War only brings destruction

Amid reports that the US President Donald Trump has suspended further strikes on Iran, it appears that both he and the new Ayatollah of Iran may be considering an end to the war currently intensifying in West Asia. However, the situation does not reflect any real restoration of peace and normalcy in the region. It seems that the President is attempting to create a clean image for himself, which the world clearly understands to be contradictory. It is regrettable and unfortunate that the American President is comparing Iran with Venezuela. Under no circumstances will he be able to take over Iran in the same manner as Venezuela. Triggering war that leads to huge losses to humanity, property, and energy infrastructure does not make any sense. The need of the hour is to restore peace and normalcy in the region. It would be better to engage in dialogue and cooperate to settle the conflict as soon as possible on mutually agreed terms. America must understand that if it has tensions with any country, it becomes a matter of concern for the entire world. At present, no country is in a position to afford the continuation of this war any longer. Therefore, in the wider interest of the world, it is highly necessary to end this war as soon as possible.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR



EV: Why India must shift gears to infrastructure financing

As the country targets 30 per cent EV penetration by 2030 and eyes a \$200 billion opportunity, the real challenge is no longer demand but building a robust, well-financed ecosystem of charging networks and grid support that can power the next phase of growth

FIRST
Column



RIA
SINHA

The electric vehicle (EV) transition in India has been quite steady in the last few years; however, a slight dip is noticeable recently. Based on estimates, EV sales have crossed roughly 2.2 mn units in 2025, witnessing a market penetration of 7.6 per cent as against a market penetration of 1 per cent in 2019. The market has seen major uptake in the electric 2W and 3W categories; however, commercial fleets, electric cars and buses are gradually catching up. The Indian government has been quite persistent in its efforts by putting the right policies in place, first through FLAME and now through PM E-DRIVE. India has announced ambitious targets — EVs are expected to have a market penetration of 30 per cent by 2030, which basically means a 22 per cent increase from the present rate in the next 5 years. Based on NITI Aayog estimates, India's EV transition is likely to unlock \$200bn by 2035, generating over 10 mn jobs across manufacturing, charging infrastructure and related services. Needless to mention, market penetration will depend heavily on EV adoption, which in turn will be driven by enabling infrastructure across different segments and geographies.

The present EV space has been largely driven by investments in vehicle manufacturing rather than in infrastructure development. As of now, the space has been majorly dominated by private corporate capital, particularly from vehicle manufacturers financing manufacturing capacity and product development through internal accruals and balance sheet investments. This is followed by venture capital and growth equity investors who have supported EV start-ups and battery technology platforms, while banks and NBFCs are increasingly financing vehicle purchases, especially 2W and 3W. Public capital has majorly played a catalytic role through policy incentives, subsidies and concessional funding supported by multilateral institutions. However, these investments have largely remained uneven across the ecosystem: vehicle manufacturing has attracted significant private capital vis-à-vis financing for charging infrastructure, grid integration and large-scale



THE PRESENT EV SPACE HAS BEEN LARGELY DRIVEN BY INVESTMENTS IN VEHICLE MANUFACTURING RATHER THAN IN INFRASTRUCTURE DEVELOPMENT

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fleet electrification, which remains limited due to uncertain utilisation rates, long payback periods, and land and other infrastructure requirements. Revenues depend heavily on local EV adoption patterns, electricity tariffs and policy stability. At the same time, charging infrastructure is fundamentally location-dependent: the viability of a station depends on access to strategically located urban land such as parking areas, transport hubs, commercial centres or logistics depots. Securing such land often involves high leasing costs, complex municipal approvals and short tenure agreements that do not match the financing horizons preferred by investors.

The nature of the financing challenge is evolving. In metropolitan regions such as Delhi-NCR, charging and battery-swapping networks for 2Ws and 3Ws have expanded significantly in recent years. Private operators and start-ups have begun building dense networks, particularly for delivery fleets and shared mobility services. This suggests that, in some large metropolitan markets, infrastructure financing for smaller EV segments may gradually be becoming more viable. However, this progress remains uneven. Charging

infrastructure remains a significant challenge in tier-2 and tier-3 cities. Limited demand visibility, smaller fleet sizes and weaker distribution networks make infrastructure deployment in these regions financially challenging. In addition, access to suitable land for charging stations - whether municipal parking spaces, commercial complexes or transport nodes — remains limited in many smaller cities, where local planning frameworks for EV infrastructure are still evolving. Without targeted interventions, charging networks may remain concentrated in tier-1 cities, slowing EV adoption elsewhere. Based on NITI Aayog analysis, the scale of infrastructure required to support EV transition and energy efficiency goals in India is immense. India presently has roughly 25,000 public EV charging stations but might require nearly 2.9 million by 2035 to support EV growth. EV infrastructure in India remains well below the global benchmarks. The country has about 52 public charging points per mn people, vis-à-vis 580 in the United States and over 2,500 in China. These numbers illustrate the magnitude of investment required to sustain large-scale electrification.

Estimates highlight the scale of the broader investment challenge. Sector experts suggest that India's electric transport transition could require hundreds of billions of dollars in cumulative investment over the coming decades, including both vehicles and supporting infrastructure. Mobilising such capital will require moving beyond pilots toward a more mature financing ecosystem.

Moving forward, India's EV policy needs to shift from primary EV adoption to enabling infrastructure financing. Immense opportunities exist to unlock capital from domestic financial intermediaries and international MDBs. The need of the hour is a holistic policy which will enable the financing framework.

First, perceived risks related to utilisation, demand, tariff structures and site-level economics such as land costs and tenure security need to be addressed by policymakers.

Targeted credit guarantees - partial or first loss - can help attract institutional investments. Concessional capital from DFIs could absorb early-stage utilisation risks and improve credit ratings for EV

infrastructure projects. But such mechanisms should remain temporary. Overreliance on concessional finance risks distorting market signals, thereby crowding out commercial discipline. BF must therefore taper as the market matures and asset performance data improves.

Second, financial innovations through aggregation models, as demonstrated by CESL. By aggregating demand across multiple cities, standardising contracts, and offering stronger payment assurance mechanisms, CESL significantly improved project bankability and reduced costs. The same principle can be extended to EV infrastructure. Infrastructure finance works best at the portfolio level, where aggregating charging stations diversifies risk and can enable capital-market financing through securitisation or green asset-backed securities.

Third, financial regulators also have an important role to play. RBI retains several developmental policy tools that could accelerate the sector's growth. Explicit PSL recognition for EV infrastructure, calibrated risk weights for EV asset pools, and clearer securitisation frameworks could help lower financing costs and attract institutional capital.

Fourth, municipal and state-level financing mechanisms will be critical for scaling electrified public transport. Cities could leverage green municipal bonds and PPPs to finance electric bus fleets and charging depots. Equally important will be city-level planning frameworks that allocate public land such as bus depots, metro stations and municipal parking facilities for EV charging infrastructure.

Finally, public finance should be deployed strategically to support infrastructure expansion in underserved regions.

Targeted viability gap funding, concessional credit lines or blended finance platforms could help crowd in private investment in tier-2 and tier-3 cities where demand remains uncertain but long-term potential is significant.

India's EV transition is entering a decisive phase. The ambition is strong and the market interest is visible. The challenge now is no longer simply adoption; it is institutionalisation. Whether the next decade delivers truly scalable electrification will depend less on how many vehicles are sold and more on whether India can design the financial system capable of sustaining them.

Assassination bid on Farooq Abdullah exposes grave security lapses



DINESH
SINGH CHAUHAN

On March 11, 2026, former Chief Minister of Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) and President of the Jammu & Kashmir National Conference (JKNC), Farooq Abdullah, survived an assassination attempt on his life at a marriage function in Jammu's Greater Kailash area.

In the CCTV footage released soon after the attack, as soon as Dr Farooq was leaving and started walking towards the exit, the assailant came from behind and was seen pulling out a pistol while moving closer to Farooq Abdullah from behind and firing a shot at him while he was leaving the event, along with Deputy Chief Minister Surinder Kumar Choudhary, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah's adviser Nasir Aslam Wani, and other party leaders. The alert security guards overpowered the assailant and took control of his hand and the weapon the moment he fired while deflecting the shot.

Farooq Abdullah has Z+ security (the highest level of protective cover in India) and is among the most highly protected politicians in the region, prompting some politicians to describe the incident as a "major security lapse". The security personnel from the close protection team overpowered the assailant to foil a bid to end the former Chief Minister's life. The assailant was eventually overpowered by the security personnel of the Deputy Chief Minister, Surinder Choudhary, who detained the attacker and transported him in a security vehicle for handing him over to the police. No doubt, it was a close shave. A miracle has saved him.

The police deployment was poor and an investigation should be conducted to get to the bottom of this very disturbing security lapse. Why was the facility of frisking unavailable at the event? There are more questions than answers at the moment, including how someone was able to get this close to a Z+ NSG-protected former Chief Minister. How such a breach could occur despite 88-year-old Farooq Abdullah being a Z+ protectee, the highest level of civilian security in the country that entails round-the-clock protection by the elite National Security Guard (NSG) commandos along with local police deployment, is a serious concern.

The function was attended by many VVIPs, including sitting High Court judges, retired Chief Justices, and High Court judges. There was no bandobast of local police, when the SP South, Dy SP, and even the concerned Station House Officer were conspicuous by their absence from the banquet hall. Those entrusted with maintaining

law and order must be held accountable.

While such condemnation and demands for accountability are necessary, the incident should not be viewed as an isolated act. It is gravely shocking and disturbing that if Farooq Abdullah, a towering national leader, is not safe in this environment, then who else can be? Although First Information Report No. 29/2006 has been registered under Section 109 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) (attempt to murder) read with Section 3/25 of the Indian Arms Act, and a seven-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) headed by DIG JSK Range Shiv Kumar Sharma has been constituted by the Inspector General of Police, Jammu, to conduct a thorough probe into the assassination bid on National Conference President and three-time former Jammu & Kashmir Chief Minister Farooq Abdullah, the investigation is being conducted scientifically and technically in a satisfactory manner, but unfortunately an independent committee headed by a retired High Court judge has not been constituted to thoroughly investigate the serious and grave security lapse by the local police and fix accountability for appropriate action.

The Home Minister, who personally spoke to Farooq Abdullah immediately after the assassination bid, checked on his well-being. The Home Minister assured Farooq Abdullah that the motive of the assailant would be fully ascertained and the investigation would be transparent.

Although His Excellency the Lieutenant Governor of the Union Territory of Jammu & Kashmir, Manoj Sinha, spoke with National Conference President and former Chief Minister Farooq Abdullah following the assassination attempt on the veteran leader

during a wedding function in Jammu, and assured that a thorough investigation would be carried out into the incident, further directing the Director General of Police, Nalin Prabhat, to leave no stone unturned in getting to the bottom of the matter and ensuring that appropriate action follows swiftly, the security establishment needs to be instructed to guarantee airtight security arrangements for Farooq Abdullah. These assurances are significant, but the gravity of the incident requires that the inquiry into the security lapse itself be placed beyond all doubt.

While the registration of the FIR and constitution of the SIT are necessary and welcome steps, they address only one part of the issue, namely the criminal investigation into the assailant, his motive, his background, and the larger circumstances of the attack. An equally serious and distinct issue arises regarding the apparent security failure and the adequacy of local police arrangements at the venue.

The disturbing question that still cries for an answer is this: how could an armed individual come so close to a Z+ protectee and discharge a firearm at a public function attended by

several dignitaries? If such a breach could occur in relation to Farooq Abdullah, then the matter transcends an individual incident and becomes one of institutional failure demanding urgent review and accountability.

The incident, therefore, cannot be viewed as an isolated act alone. It raises grave concerns regarding:

- Venue sanitisation and access control;
- Frisking arrangements and weapon screening;
- Local police presence and bandobast;
- Co-ordination between central protection personnel and local police;
- Perimeter security and crowd regulation; and
- Emergency reaction protocols in mixed civilian-VVIP gatherings.

The fact that the assassination bid was ultimately foiled does not dilute the seriousness of the lapse; rather, it highlights how narrowly a tragedy was averted. A failed assassination attempt on such a heavily protected senior leader is itself evidence of a deeply troubling breach in the protective security architecture.

In these circumstances, a separate and independent inquiry should be constituted to examine the entire chain of security arrangements and to fix responsibility wherever negligence, omission, or dereliction of duty is found.

The incident has also compelled an immediate reassessment of existing VIP security protocols. Given the extraordinary nature of the breach, the competent authorities may also consider a review and strengthening of Farooq Abdullah's already existing security arrangements, including stricter venue access control, enhanced local co-ordination, and any other additional measures deemed necessary by the security establishment. Recent reporting indicates that the Home Ministry is reviewing VIP security protocols following the incident.

An attack on Farooq Abdullah is not merely an attack on an individual politician; it is an attack on a senior public figure whose life and role are deeply intertwined with the political history of Jammu and Kashmir. The people are entitled to safety, stability, and confidence in the institutions entrusted with maintaining law and order. Those entrusted with such responsibility must be held accountable where serious lapses are revealed. Therefore, responsibility of the concerned local police and supervisory officers must be fixed after due inquiry, and Farooq Abdullah's security arrangements must be immediately reviewed and strengthened so as to guarantee airtight protection against any recurrence.

The writer is a Senior Advocate and President of the National Conference Legal Wing (headed by Dr Abdullah)

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RITIKA
JOSHI

The sinking of the Iranian warship IRIS Dena in the Indian Ocean after a US strike may appear at first glance to be a limited military episode. However, maritime history suggests that events like this often function as early signals of larger geopolitical shifts.

For centuries, these waters formed one of the most stable trading environments in world history. Long before the rise of European empires, merchants navigated the monsoon system connecting the Persian Gulf, the western coast of India, East Africa and Southeast Asia. Horses from Arabia, textiles from Gujarat and spices from the Indonesian archipelago moved across these routes. Even the Portuguese, Dutch and British empires largely focused on controlling strategic ports and choke points rather than engaging in continuous naval conflict across the ocean.

Yet the structural importance of the Indian Ocean has grown dramatically in the 21st century. Today, the region carries nearly 80-90 per cent of global trade by volume, roughly two-thirds of seaborne oil shipments, and more than half of global container traffic. The energy lifelines of East Asia pass through these waters, while Europe's trade with Asia depends heavily on the same sea lanes. Therefore, the sinking of Dena in the middle of one of the busiest maritime systems on the planet will have strategic implications.

When major powers project force into heavily trafficked sea lanes, the geopolitical character of those waters changes. The Mediterranean is one example. For centuries, it served as an intensive commercial zone between Europe, North Africa and the Levant, yet towards the end of the 19th and early 20th centuries it was transformed into a battleground of strategic interests among empires. Similarly, the South China Sea, which was initially a largely commercial maritime passageway, transformed into one of the most disputed security spaces in Asia as regional powers started to claim competing ownership of the region and increased their naval capacity.

The Indian Ocean is entering a comparable phase. The growing naval presence of multiple powers shows the scale of the transformation. The United States has one of its largest operational deployments in the region through its Fifth Fleet and associated bases. China has expanded its reach through regular naval patrols and logistical infrastructure along the western Indian Ocean. India has also strengthened maritime surveillance networks and naval operations across the Arabian Sea and Bay of Bengal. Each of these

actors views the stability of sea lanes as essential, yet their overlapping strategic interests are gradually thickening the security environment.

The case of the sinking of IRIS Dena is no exception. As a naval conflict reaches a major business route, the impact is not limited to direct military action. There is a reaction in insurance markets, a re-evaluation of routes by shipping companies, and governments start to recalculate risks on a maritime region-wide basis. The Indian Ocean is sensitive to such shocks, especially because it is the main connector between the energy supplies of the Gulf and the industrial economies of Asia.

For India, the implications are both immediate and long term. The relationship between India and Iran has been based on energy trade, cultural ties and various strategically located projects, including the Chabahar port, which opens access to Central Asia bypassing Pakistan. At the same time, India's partnership with the United States has deepened significantly over the past two decades.

The sinking of IRIS Dena in the US strike thus creates a sensitive diplomatic situation for India. New Delhi will hardly be ready to explain the incident through explicitly partisan positions. Rather, it is likely to focus on maritime security, freedom of navigation and the necessity to avoid escalation in one of the areas vital to international trade. Such a stance allows New Delhi to preserve its strategic partnership with Washington while maintaining working relations with Tehran.

This balanced approach is supported by geography. With a coastline of more than 7,500 kilometres and an exclusive economic zone exceeding two million square kilometres, India is at the centre of the maritime routes that connect the Persian Gulf to East and Southeast Asia. Nearly 95 per cent of India's trade by volume moves through these sea lanes. Any prolonged instability would therefore affect not only regional security but also India's economic trajectory.

In the coming decade, several trends are likely to become more visible. As states seek to monitor critical sea lanes more closely and aggressively, investments in satellites, radar networks and underwater surveillance will expand, and strategic chokepoints such as the Strait of Hormuz and Bab-el-Mandeb will attract even greater attention.

However, none of these developments necessarily means that the Indian Ocean will become a full-scale battlefield. But the assumption that these waters exist primarily as neutral corridors of commerce will be hard to sustain. In that sense, the sinking of IRIS Dena may mark a turning point.

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STOCK-SHOCK THERAPY



Yesterday, the Sensex, or the Bombay Stock Exchange index, ended up nearly 1,400 points, or almost 1,000 points higher than its intra-day low. It opened 700 points above the previous day's close, dipped by almost 200 points, traced its upward curve, before it settled down almost 400 points from the intra-day high. The trajectory ostensibly seems to mirror the rapid sequence of geopolitical events, and statements from various sides in the Iran war, but it seems to defy some logic by adding almost two per cent in the end. The topsy-turvy movement reflected the chaos and confusion, but one is not sure why it ended in the green. There is a possible theory. The Sensex is beginning to latch on to any bit of good news, even if it is denied later, and does the opposite at the onset of bad news, which is reversed later. It is as if the dazed investors are being coerced by stock-shock therapy.

One of the major factors, contend experts, for the bull push, or rather pull, was due to the statement by the US president, Donald Trump, which stated that he had extended the deadline for Iran to reopen the strategic and crucial Strait of Hormuz to restart global crude oil supplies. After going back on a 48-hour ultimatum that warned against brutal strikes on power plants, he gave a five-day reprieve. In addition, he maintained that the US diplomats were holding talks with a "respected" Iranian leader, and Iran was interested in a "deal." Pakistan added a wrinkle, and stated that it would possibly host the bilateral peace talks between the US and Iran. Asian stocks, including the Indian ones, followed the American counterparts the previous night. This showed that Trump was distancing from the war cries, and resorting to peace pipes, as the war shows no signs of ending.

However, after the five-day reprieve statement, Iranian sources dubbed it as fake news, and said that no talks were in progress. Indeed, the fighting continued, as Iran bombarded a few targets, Iran did the same, the US missiles took to the skies, and there was news that a Shia militant group, which supported the Iranian regime, was attacked, and its leader killed. One of the US officials clarified that the five-day window was to not attack Iran's power plants, as claimed in Trump's 48-hour ultimatum, but the attacks on non-energy targets will continue. It was clear that there were no signs of peace talks. Pakistan claims had a logical base but lacked credibility. Although it was a friendly zone for talks, Pakistan was at war with Afghanistan. Indeed, Pakistan sources had warned that it would nuke India if someone interfered in its border war. But the Sensex believed the peace talks, and Indian equities followed the rise in American stocks the previous night.

Global crude prices reflected this off-on statements about war and peace. They came down sharply below \$100 a barrel, and hovered around \$90, down below \$100 for the first time in several weeks. But they went up again to over \$100. Obviously, there were fresh fears and concerns about supplies through the Strait after Iran denied Trump's statements, and the battles continued in the Middle East. But one must say that oil has shown a stubbornness in the recent past. After an initial rise to \$120, and fears of \$150-200, including Iranian claims that it will become \$200, the price has remained around \$100. Gold was down for the nth day as the war showed no signs of de-escalating in the future. The downward trend in both the bullion and equities, as with other asset classes, except possibly bonds, is a mystery that few experts can explain. Normally, in crises and periods of tensions, gold goes up as a hedge.

Sensex possibly missed another domestic cue, as it became engaged with what was happening in the US and Iran. According to a media report, "The flash India Composite Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI), compiled by S&P Global for HSBC, fell to 56.5 in March (2026). This was significantly below the Reuters poll median estimate of 59, and lower than February's final reading of 58.9, which had been expected to remain largely unchanged.... The manufacturing sector was hit the hardest, with its PMI dropping to a four-and-a-half year low of 53.8 from 56.9.... The services sector, which makes up the largest share of India's GDP, also showed signs of slowing with its PMI slipping to 57.2 from 58.1." The figures indicate a loss of economic-manufacturing momentum, and "underline the potential downside risks to both India's growth outlook, and global economy." In the last quarter, which ended months before the Iran war, India's growth came down from an unusually-high 8.4 per cent to a still-unusually-high 7.8 per cent.

However, what is pertinent is that economists and rating agencies are quickly scaling down the growth in India, and other nations. From 6.7 per cent annual estimates before the war, India's figure is down below six per cent. This reflects a wiping out of 0.5 per cent within a few weeks. If the war continues, the figure may dip further. Combined with the falling rupee, high inflation, and shortages in crucial products, the economy may go for a spin, even as it faces other challenges.

The Pioneer



NEW DELHI | WEDNESDAY | MARCH 25, 2026

BUSINESS10

Anil's telco dues, Mukesh's cues

Twisted twin tales of two brothers show signs of tatters and titters

As the legal pressures mount, scathing comments emerge from the Supreme Court, government sets up a special team to investigate the criminal cases, and there is an official assurance that "no stone shall be left unturned to unearth the truth" within four weeks, the beleaguered Anil Ambani of the ADAG Group has capitulated. According to a media report, his lawyers told the Supreme Court that he was ready to settle the banks' dues of Reliance Communications (RCom) in a "staggered" fashion. The loans relate to ₹40,000 crore (some say ₹73,000 crore), many of which were declared fraudulent by the banks. Petitions nudged the Supreme Court to put pressure on the investigating agencies.

While claiming that he was not an absconder, and was unlikely to run away from the country, and he had helped the investigating agencies, Anil passed on a message that he was willing to talk to the lenders as a first step towards payments over a specific 'undecided' period. The involvement of the apex court was essential because the banks had refused to engage because of an ongoing probe. The Chief Justice stated that there was no bar on such talks, but the government rejected the proposal. The latter argued that payments cannot be the only solution in a criminal case. In this instance, the loans were fraudulent.

The fact remains that the RCom case involves several crucial issues, which were discussed, debated, and partly-accepted by the Supreme Court. The latter stated recently, "It is pointed out that investigations / enquiries into eight cases have commenced, and some documents have been seized. It is not necessary for us to refer to the nature of documents.... There is a reference to Project Help, which is said to have revealed

how insolvency petitions (under the bankruptcy laws) were deliberately initiated through unrelated lenders. According to the report, all funding by IBC acquisitions were arranged through a group of eight NBFCs (non-banking finance companies). On an illustrative basis, it is pointed out that claims approximating ₹2,983 crore were extinguished for a total settlement of ₹26 crore."

In effect, there was a collusion between the bankrupt firm, possibly RCom, and parties which initiated the bankruptcy proceedings. Under the insolvency law, any party that can prove a default in payment can initiate an action. The next part of the collusion took place between the new owner, who purchased the firm or its assets, and the NBFCs that funded the acquisition. In the process, there was a third collusion between the bankers, lenders, and creditors, who settled their outstanding claims for less than a hundredth, or one per cent of the amount. In the past such huge haircuts, or acceptance of low amounts compared to the loans, of more than 90 per cent were observed in several cases. But this is unbelievable, a haircut of 99.1 per cent.

What is more important is that during the previous hearings on the RCom issue in the Supreme Court, the petitioners had insisted that the firm was sold under the insolvency laws to Anil Ambani's elder brother, Mukesh, for a song, or a payment of one per cent of the dues. In this context, the Chief Justice observed that the court had witnessed similar cases, where family members, relatives, and fiends legally took over the defaulting firms for peanuts. As a media report stated, the Chief Justice felt that the "IBC

(insolvency law, Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code) was being misused like anything by undervaluing the company's assets, and selling them off to proxy (possibly friendly) parties."

Of course, such multi-layered, multi-level, and multi-agency collusions raises the possibilities of support from public servants, especially the bankers of state-owned creditors and lenders. As the Supreme Court observed in the RCom case, "This is a case where senior functionaries of the investigating agencies must join hands, and make vigorous attempts to unearth the irregularities / illegalities or the connivance of public functionaries, especially the financial institutions, if any, in giving undue benefit.... While we do not express any opinion on the merits of the allegations... it is imperative... to complete the investigation in a most dispassionate, fair, transparent, and independent manner, and take... (it) to a logical conclusion...."

However, the curious case of insolvency of RCom is not as straightforward as it looks, despite the various twists and turns that involve the original owner, new management, creditors, public servants, investigating agencies, and NBFCs. In 2022, Mukesh Ambani acquired the assets of RCom, which included the towers, and optic fibre, but not the company. Later, a subsidiary of RCom, Reliance Communications Infrastructure, got an oral approval from an insolvent court to be purchased by Mukesh Ambani. But the firm, RCom, whose revival plan by an asset reconstruction company was approved, remains in a limbo. As of now, it is still under the insolvency process.

In the process, Mukesh Ambani has access to most of the assets of the RCom, and it was (before the bankruptcy), and is using them. But the current case before the Supreme Court, where the name of the elder brother was dragged, may change the dynamics. Although, one does not know if the courts will reverse the insolvency revival plans once the payments were made to the lenders, and the assets merged with Mukesh's firms. In addition, the asset reconstruction firm's bid to acquire the spectrum of RCom is being legally debated in a fresh manner because of a ruling by the apex court that spectrum does not belong to a firm, but is a public asset or resource that can be used for public good.

At the same time, having bagged the telecom assets that belonged to the younger brother, and which the elder sibling lost during the family split in 2005, Mukesh is on the way to bigger conquests. According to media reports, one of his flagships, Reliance Jio, started the process towards the country's largest IPO (Initial Public Offering). Last year, Mukesh promised it in the first half of 2026. But the Supreme Court, if it acts against both the Ambani brothers, may create hiccups. Hence, the telco tales of the two brothers are intertwined and entangled despite the two-decade-old separation. Their telecom destinies converge again, as they did when they were together, and diverged when they fought over the Reliance Group. Mukesh waited for years before he started his telco journey with Jio, which led to takeover of RCom assets.

The Tech Wrecker

Conveniences come at a cost

Revenues explode in quick commerce; profits are more iffy

ry holding-handling, and depends on consistent replenishments. A part of these costs are incurred before the demand stabilises at high threshold levels, and another part needs to be spent irrespective of whether one earns profits. The deliveries are sacrosanct, so is product availability.

Most firms may be able to run such operations, if the revenues followed a value-based trajectory, or big-ticket orders. In other words, if volumes translated into higher values, as the average size of the orders increased with the number of orders. Brokerage houses estimate that the average order value is in the ₹400-600 range, which reflects a small order size, although they may be high-frequency or volume purchases. Revenues are, therefore, driven by frequency growth, and the value per order does not expand proportionately. Hence, volume densities become imperative, not the ticket sizes.

Logically, the business model depends on high-order density within tightly-defined

catchments. The trick is to get a higher number of orders within short distances so that 10-minute deliveries are possible. This explains why a new Blinkit store takes 12-18 months to break even. Expansion, which is essential for scale, can defer profits. The dependence on density explains why quick commerce remains an urban phenomenon, or largely limited to the larger cities. The model works best in high-income, high-density neighbourhoods in Bengaluru, Delhi-NCR, and Mumbai, where demand exists within a small radius.

In tier-2 cities, lower density and lower frequency make it harder to achieve viable economics. In rural markets and semi-urban pockets, where purchasing power, infrastructure, and delivery differ, the model is largely absent. India is a price-sensitive market, yet quick commerce relies on consumers accepting the costs of conveniences via delivery fees, slightly-higher pricing, or reduced discounts. This is possible in the metros

where time-saving carries a premium, and is worth the extra bucks. Yet, if competition offers lower prices, or higher discounts, or zero fees, the models can go haywire. They become extremely fragile.

This is where capital plays a role. The expansion of dark store networks, delivery fleets, and inventory systems become crucial. The quick path to profitability in quick commerce depends on operational efficiencies, and inflow of large amounts of capital. But investors are shifting focus from order value growth to other metrics such as contribution margins, store-level throughput, and payback periods. Zomato's valuation is closely tied to Blinkit's ability to demonstrate that scale can translate into sustainable earnings. One can see the impact. Platforms push higher-margin categories such as electronics and personal care to increase basket sizes. Private labels improve margins.

Advertising within the app is a revenue stream, as brands compete for visibility in a controlled digital environment. These changes help but do not alter the cost structure, which is anchored in proximity and speed. The broader retail ecosystem changes. Local grocery stores, which rely on small-ticket purchases, are losing out to quick commerce. The latter, in turn, competes with the former, and sometimes operates via the local stores. Local shops, which encouraged bulk-buying, are losing the same to the large physical retailers, who offer larger discounts due to scale.

FMCG firms recalibrate strategies, and redesign product formats, and promotional spends to suit app-based discovery. Globally, similar models faced challenges. Getir and Gopuff scaled aggressively, only to exit multiple markets, undertake layoffs, and rationalise costs. The next phase for Indian firms will depend on cost-profit-expansion balance. If order density rises, basket sizes improve, and costs stabilise, quick commerce may emerge as a viable urban retail layer. If growth slows, the model risks being dependent on capital inflows. If capital stays away, there are chances of retrenchment, and lower scales. Quick commerce demonstrates that it can reshape consumer buying. The test is whether the economics catch up, or whether expectation of conveniences push expansion, and higher costs.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

Stock markets jump nearly 2% as Trump halts strikes on Iran

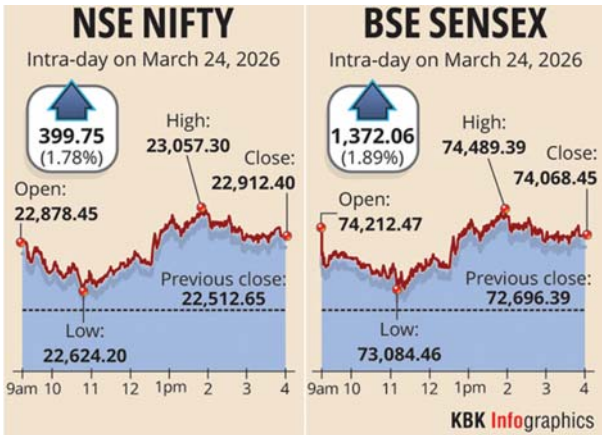
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty rebounded by nearly 2 per cent on Tuesday, tracking a rally in Asian peers after US President Donald Trump announced a temporary halt on strikes targeting Iranian energy infrastructure.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 1,372.06 points or 1.89 per cent to settle at 74,068.45. During the day, it soared 1,793 points or 2.46 per cent to 74,489.39.

The 50-share NSE Nifty surged 399.75 points or 1.78 per cent to end at 22,912.40.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Larsen & Toubro, InterGlobe Aviation, Eternal, Asian Paints, Bajaj Finance and UltraTech Cement were the biggest



winners. Power Grid and State Bank of India were the only laggards from the pack. Trump said on social media that he has extended the deadline for Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, the strategically located shipping

lane between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman, and that he will hold off strikes against Iranian energy sites for five days. "Indian equities witnessed a constructive rebound, with markets closing on a positive

note after the sharp sell-off in the previous session.

The recovery was largely driven by a moderation in risk perception, as early signs of potential de-escalation in the ongoing US-Iran tensions helped restore some investor confidence," Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth, said. The rally also needs to be viewed in context, he said.

"After a sharp, sentiment-driven correction, such rebounds are not uncommon and often reflect a combination of short covering and value buying. Investors typically use such dislocations to accumulate quality stocks at relatively attractive valuations, rather than it being a signal of a structural trend reversal," Hariprasad added.

Rupee slumps 35 paise to settle at all-time low of 93.88 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

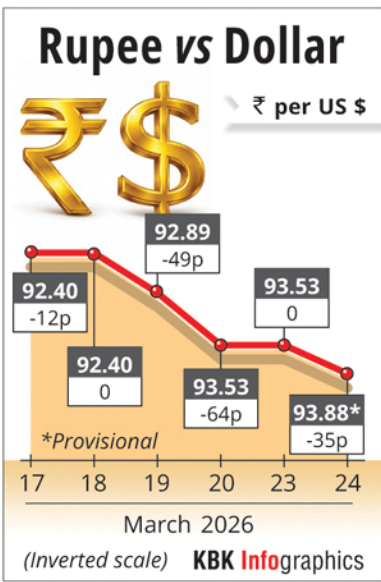
The rupee dropped 35 paise to 93.88 (provisional) against the US dollar on Tuesday as a strengthening greenback against major crosses and elevated global crude prices spooked investors.

Foreign fund outflows amid uncertainties over the West Asia crisis further weighed on the local unit, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the local unit opened at 93.66 against the greenback and remained volatile throughout the session. It eventually settled at 93.88 (provisional), down 35 paise from its previous close.

The rupee breached the 94-level against the US dollar for the first time on Monday, before closing flat at 93.53.

"Persistent FPI outflows continue to pressure INR. A strong US dollar is keeping emerging market currencies weak, and the INR has weakened by about 4.5 per cent during the month.



The rupee range for Wednesday is expected to be 93.65 to 94.25," Anil Kumar Bhansali, Head of Treasury and

Executive Director, Finrex Treasury Advisors LLP, said. Trump on Monday said the US was talking with a "respect-ed" Iranian leader and claimed the Islamic Republic was eager for a deal to end the war.

He also extended the deadline for Iran to reopen the crucial Strait of Hormuz or face attacks on its power plants, saying it has an additional five days.

However, Iran's denial of Trump's claims and continued hostilities in the region created uncertainty, pushing up global crude oil prices.

The dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading 0.23 per cent higher at 99.18.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading 1.45 per cent lower at \$101.4 per barrel in futures trade.

On the domestic equity market front, the Sensex rose sharply by 1,372.06 points, or 1.89 per cent, to 74,068.45, while the Nifty was up 209.65 points, or 0.93 per cent, to 22,722.30.

We can mobilise ₹8 lakh cr per year for road projects: Gadkari

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Concerned over the slow pace of spending in the highways sector, Union Minister Nitin Gadkari on Tuesday said the Government can mobilise up to ₹8 lakh crore per year for road projects.

Highway building has a great relevance from a socio-economic perspective and higher spends can help push the economic growth of the country, Gadkari said, adding that every ₹1 spent on infrastructure drives ₹3 worth of economic activity.

"Our problem is we are unable to spend. Our speed of spending is too low," Gadkari said, speaking at the listing ceremony of NHAI-sponsored Rajjarmg Infra Investment Trust at the BSE.

The Government can raise

₹5 lakh crore per year from the market on the back of the strong asset profile in the highways sector, in addition to the budgetary support of ₹3.2 lakh crore.

Citing the Dwarka Expressway project near the national capital as a case of trickle-down benefits of infrastructure spending, he said the stretch that was a forest earlier has attracted over ₹8 lakh crore in realty investments.

Gadkari said the ground-breaking for a slew of projects involving up to ₹40,000 crore in spending in and around Pune will be done in the next fortnight. These include the Pune-Aurangabad Expressway and also four other projects.

The minister also mentioned about plans being underway to build a new Mumbai-Bengaluru express



Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari addressing a press conference in Mumbai on Tuesday

highway which will cut the travel time between the financial and tech capitals of the country to five hours.

On the Mumbai-Goa national highway, Gadkari said issues include land acquisitions which led to delay in implementation of the project started in 2010.

The Union Minister for

Road Transport and Highways said 93 per cent of works on the highway are over and the construction will be complete in another two months.

He will also be inspecting the works on April 10 this year. The ministry does not begin work on a project till a bulk of the land acquisition is

not complete, he said. He admitted that the pace of highway construction has slipped to 32-34 km per day from the earlier 40 km, even as the ministry has been targeting to increase it to 60 km per day.

When asked about construction quality of roads, Gadkari said the amount of complaints is very less and added that putting the onus on contractors has helped.

The ministry, which is targeting to convert all the 900 toll plazas into multi lane free flow ones by end of the year, will soon be posting 105 tenders for creation of such facilities.

Gadkari said the Government is saving over ₹8,000 crore per year due to technology implementations at the toll plazas as the operation costs go down, he said.

Silver futures slide ₹9,467 to ₹2.15 lakh/kg; extends 10-day rout amid volatility

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Silver prices remained under heavy selling pressure for the 10th straight session declining by ₹9,467 to ₹2.15 lakh per kilogramme in futures trade on Tuesday amid heightened volatility and weak global cues.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), the white metal for May delivery slumped by ₹9,467, or 4.2 per cent, to ₹2,15,700 per kilogram.

In the previous session, silver had nosedived ₹27,129, or 12 per cent, to hit an intra-day low of ₹1,99,643 per kg before trimming losses to settle at ₹2,25,167 per kg,

along with concerns around the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, continue to keep inflation risks elevated and weighed on the investor's sentiment.

Meanwhile, silver futures on the Comex also tumbled for the 10th straight session in the global markets.

The white metal for the May contract fell \$1.71, or 2.47 per cent, to \$67.64 per ounce from the previous close of \$69.35 per ounce.

The metal has lost nearly \$22, or 24.50 per cent, from \$89.59 per ounce recorded on March 10, 2026.

On Monday, US President Donald Trump indicated a delay in potential military strikes on Iran's power



down ₹1,605, or 0.71 per cent. The precious metal has dropped ₹62,150, or 22.36 per cent, in the past 10 sessions from ₹2,77,850 per kg recorded on March 10, 2026.

Analysts said the sharp decline reflects sustained liquidation in precious metals, although intermittent short-covering has offered some support at lower levels.

"Silver has rebounded from key psychological supports near ₹2 lakh per kg supported by oversold conditions and short-covering," Renisha Chainani, Head of Research at Augmont, said.

She added that persistent tensions in West Asia and uncertainty over potential negotiations,

plants and energy infrastructure and mentioned "productive discussions".

This has eased immediate safe-haven demand for dollar. Additionally, declining global bond yields lent support to bullion.

However, Tehran has denied any ongoing talks with the US, while Israel continued its military actions in Iran.

Analysts noted that conflicting statements from the US and Iran have sustained geopolitical uncertainty, keeping market volatility elevated.

Chainani said the recent selloff reflects a classic liquidity-driven phase, where investors liquidate profitable assets like gold and silver to meet margin calls in other asset classes.

After Zomato, Swiggy hikes platform fee by 17% to ₹17.58 per order



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Food delivery platform Swiggy has hiked the platform fee it charges users to ₹17.58 per order, its app showed on Tuesday, days after rival Zomato increased the charges. Swiggy had last hiked its platform fee in September last year.

The company has now raised it to ₹17.58 per order inclusive of GST, whereas rival Zomato charges ₹14.90 on a pre-GST basis. The latest round of increase by Swiggy brings the platform fee

charged by both food delivery players effectively at par with each other (to around ₹17.58 per order).

On March 20, Zomato hiked the platform fee it charges users by ₹2.40 to ₹14.90 per order on a pre-GST basis.

Platform fees are fixed, per-order charges in addition to delivery and restaurant fees. To cover operating costs, technology maintenance, and customer support for services. The latest hike in platform fees is set to make ordering food costlier for millions of users across the country.

Industry leaders stress trust, innovation as key to building enduring institutions

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Industry leaders on Tuesday emphasised that trust, innovation and empowered organisational structures are critical for building resilient and future-ready institutions, as businesses navigate rapid technological change and evolving consumer expectations.

Speaking at the annual regional meeting and conference of the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), Eastern region, themed "Vision with Velocity", corporate leaders said institutions must balance scale with agility while remaining anchored in strong values.

ITC chairman Sanjeev Puri said long-term institutional success rests on three pillars — vision, values and vitality. "Reshaping the narrative of a legacy institution comes down to vision, values and vitality," Puri said, adding that businesses must move beyond simple diversification to build multiple drivers of growth aligned with market opportunities and

institutional strengths. He stressed that large organisations should function like "multiple startups within a larger institution", where empowered teams with clear accountability and access to technology and resources can drive innovation and agility.

CII director-general Chandrajit Banerjee said institutions must remain



anchored in trust and a "country-first" mindset while continuously evolving to address emerging challenges. "Trust across stakeholders and Governments allows institutions to maintain continuity even as they adapt to change," Banerjee said, adding that industry must strengthen research and development and invest

more in education and healthcare to support long-term economic growth.

He also said the future of India lies beyond metros — in states and districts — where industry must engage more deeply and meaningfully. Executive vice-chairperson of Apollo Hospitals Enterprise Limited, Shobhana Kamineni, said trust remains central in sectors such as healthcare, where human outcomes are directly involved.

"Trust is something we earn every day through every patient interaction and outcome," she said, adding that technology is enabling healthcare providers to expand access, standardise processes and deliver quality care beyond large cities.

However, she cautioned that technology must complement rather than replace empathy in healthcare delivery.

R Mukundan of Tata Chemicals Limited said ethical leadership and purpose-driven decision-making are essential for sustaining stakeholder confidence.

Govt to cut broken rice in PDS to free up ethanol feedstock, says food secretary

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Centre is set to approach the Cabinet with a proposal to reduce the allocation of broken rice in grains distributed under the public distribution system (PDS) from 25 per cent to 10 per cent, a move that would free roughly 90 lakh tonne of broken rice annually for the ethanol sector, Food Secretary Sanjeev Chopra said on Tuesday.

Speaking at the All India Distillers' Association (AIDA) conference, Chopra said the proposal was aimed at providing the ethanol industry with a stable, year-round feedstock supply, reducing its dependence on whole grain stocks of the Food Corporation of India (FCI).

"Climate change is a reality. We need to make sure the supply chain is not disrupted. A steady supply of broken rice to the ethanol sector will help ensure that," he said. At present, the grains distributed under PDS has

25 per cent broken rice to be provided to 80 crore beneficiaries. Under the new plan, this would be brought down to 10 per cent.

The surplus broken rice, drawn from the roughly 360-370 lakh tonne of rice distributed annually, would be sold through auction to ethanol producers, animal feed manufacturers and others. A pilot has already been conducted in five States.

From next year, the Government will stop supplying whole-grain FCI rice to distilleries. Broken rice from the revamped food scheme will take its place as the primary grain-based feed-stock, Chopra said.

"Looking further ahead, from the next ethanol supply year, whole FCI rice will no longer be available for the sector. In its place, we are moving toward the supply of broken rice, a change that addresses multiple objectives simultaneously."

This proposal serves multiple interests at once: it improves the quality of grain received by PDS



beneficiaries, eases storage and logistics pressures, and gives the ethanol sector a more stable, predictable, year-round feedstock, he said.

The announcement comes against the backdrop of a sharp rise in global crude oil prices. Brent crude, which was trading at around \$60-70 per barrel three weeks ago, has risen by nearly 40 per cent, renewing pressure on India to accelerate its ethanol

blending programme. Chopra said India's ethanol blending in petrol had already reached 20 per cent, up from just 1.5 per cent in 2013, saving the country over ₹1.63 lakh crore in foreign exchange and cutting crude oil imports by 277 lakh metric tonne since 2014.

Ethanol production capacity has grown from 420 crore litres in 2013-14 to nearly 2,000 crore litres today, with 650 crore litres added

in just the past three years. The Government is now shifting focus from supply to demand, he said, adding that raising the blending limit beyond 20 per cent, mixing ethanol with diesel, and promoting flex-fuel vehicles were all being actively considered, with decisions expected in the near future.

Chopra cited past supply disruptions as the driving force behind the structural reform. In 2023, a poor sugar harvest and concerns over rice output had forced the Government to restrict feedstock supplies to distilleries. The broken rice proposal was designed to prevent a recurrence, he said.

He also urged distilleries to expedite lifting of the current FCI rice allocation. Of the 52 lakh tonnes set aside for the current supply year, only 21 lakh tonnes had been picked up so far. A further 20 lakh tonnes remained available, but the discounted rate was valid only until June 30.

On alternative feedstocks, Chopra said maize was being

actively promoted, particularly rain-fed varieties that do not require irrigation, as part of efforts to encourage farmers to diversify away from paddy.

Around 40 per cent of ethanol supply already comes from grain-based sources, mainly maize. The agriculture ministry was also developing high-yield varieties capable of producing five to six tonnes per hectare, he added.

Referring to Brazil's experience after the 1973 oil shock — which led to an ethanol blending rate of around 30 per cent — Chopra said India's current energy crisis presented a similar opportunity to recalibrate its strategy.

"Every challenge carries within it an opportunity. This is an important moment for us to revisit and strengthen our ethanol blending programme," he said.

AIDA President Vijendra Singh said the ethanol industry was prepared to go beyond the E20 target already achieved by the country. The association demanded the Government to raise the

ethanol blending mandate gradually from 20 level.

It also called for introduction of flex-fuel vehicles capable of running on 100 per cent ethanol on the lines of Brazil, promotion of ethanol-based cook stoves for domestic and commercial use, and exploration of ethanol blending in diesel.

PS Ravi, Director (Downstream) at the Federation of Indian Petroleum Industry, called on the ethanol industry to support expansion of India's biofuel programme beyond petrol blending.

He outlined three key requests to the AIDA and its members to accelerate further biofuel adoption with respect to biodiesel blending in diesel, ethanol as cooking fuel and sustainable aviation fuel and feedstock development. Deputy Agriculture Commissioner Mehraj AS, Robert Papa, Agriculture attache at Embassy of Brazil in New Delhi were among others present at the event.

Gold rebounds ₹1,200 to ₹1.44 lakh/10g in Delhi



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Gold prices snapped a four-day losing streak and climbed ₹1,200 to ₹1.44 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Tuesday, while silver remained flat at ₹2.30 lakh per kilogram, according to the All India Sarafa Association.

The precious metal of 99.9 per cent purity had closed at ₹1,43,600 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) on Monday.

Traders attributed the rebound in domestic gold prices to a recovery in global commodity markets and some buying at lower levels after recent sharp declines.

In the international markets, spot gold rebounded after nine sessions of losses, rising \$16.96, or 0.38 per cent, to \$4,423.83 per ounce, while silver was trading 1.03 per cent higher at \$69.86 per ounce.

"Spot gold, after falling for nine straight days, is trading steady at around \$4,420 per ounce in the overseas trade on cautious optimism about the Iran war as the US President Donald Trump declared a five-day ceasefire on strikes against energy installations in Iran," Praveen Singh, Head of Commodities at Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

However, he added that doubts linger over the effectiveness of the ceasefire, keeping investors' sentiment cautious.

Analysts said the mixed signals on the geopolitical front are likely to keep bullion prices volatile in the near term.

FROM THE WORLD

US

Explosion rocks oil refinery

A large explosion at an oil refinery near the Texas coast on Monday shot plumes of smoke into the air and forced nearby residents to shelter in place, according to officials. No one was injured in the explosion at the Valero refinery in Port Arthur, about 145 kilometres east of Houston, Mayor Charlotte M. Moses said. She urged residents in parts of the west side of the city to stay put, saying fire fighters had arrived. "There's been an explosion, yes, but we're OK; everybody's OK," she said. "They're trying to put the fire out as quickly as possible." The explosion comes amid a spike in gas prices driven by uncertainty over the global oil supply because of the Iran war. The refinery has about 770 employees and can process about 435,000 barrels of oil per day.

PHILIPPINES

Fuel emergency declared

Philippine President Ferdinand Marcos Jr on Tuesday declared a state of national energy emergency to respond to the impact of the West Asia war, which his administration said posed "an imminent danger of a critically low energy supply." Under the declaration, which will initially last for a year, Marcos will lead a contingency committee that will ensure the availability and orderly distribution of fuel, food, medicines, agricultural products and other basic goods. Authorities were ordered to take action against the hoarding, profiteering and manipulation of the supply of petroleum products.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mr. Vipin Kaushik has approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Gamma, Greater Noida, U.P. (Bank) to avail a loan for purchase of Plot No. 177, (380 sq. mtrs.), Pocket/Block-B, Village/Sector-Kasna, Greater Noida, Distt. Gautam Badh Nagar, U.P. from Mr. Bijendra Singh & Mrs. Gudi Devi, who have represented that they are the absolute owners of the said property by virtue of Transfer Deed dated 29.06.2024 (Document No. 19572) executed by Mr. Yashpal Singh who was the mutatee in the record of GNIDA. If anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 7 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

Amrit Kumar (Advocate)
GNA & Associates
D-28, Jangpura Extension,
New Delhi-110014.

FORM NO. 5
DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL
600/11, University Road, Hanuman
Setu Mandir, Lucknow
SUMMONS FOR FILING REPLY &
APPEARANCE BY PUBLICATION
Dated: 03 March, 2026
Summons to defendants under
Section 19(3) of the Recovery of
Debts Due to Banks and Financial
institution Act, 1993 read with
Rules 12 and 13 of the Debts
Recovery Tribunal (Procedure)
Rules, 1993
Original Application
No. 1247 of 2025
ICICI Bank Ltd.
Vs.
Piyush Kumar & Another

To,
1. Piyush Kumar,
S/o Mr. Dalbir Singh
R/o- C-258, Janakpuri Sahibabad,
Near Shiv Mandir, Ghaziabad-
201005. ...Defendant No. 1
2. Birmati Devi
W/o Mr. Dalbir Singh
Address - C-258, Janakpuri
Sahibabad, Near Shiv Mandir,
Ghaziabad- 201005. ...Defendant No. 2

In the above noted Original
application you are required to file
reply in Paper Book form in two
sets along with documents and
affidavits (if any) personally or
through your duly authorised
agent or legal practitioner in this
Tribunal, after serving copy of the
same on the applicant or his
counsel/duly authorised agent
after publication of the summons
and thereafter to appear before
the Tribunal on 06/07/2026 at
10:30 A.M. failing which the
application shall be heard and
decided in your absence.

Registrar
Debts Recovery
Tribunal, Lucknow

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

The spokesman of Iran's top military command said on Tuesday that its armed forces will fight "until complete victory." The comments by Major General Ali Abdollahi Aliabadi of the Khatam-al Anbiya Central Headquarters appeared to be related to US President Donald Trump's announcement that there were negotiations ongoing between Tehran and Washington.

Iran has denied that any talks are taking place, though its foreign minister has been talking to counterparts around the region.

Iranian state television quoted Aliabadi as saying: "Iran's powerful armed forces

16 killed, over 4,500 injured in country since conflict: Israel

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Tel Aviv/New Delhi

Sixteen people have been killed and over 4,500 injured in Israel since the conflict with Iran began late last month, according to Israel's emergency medical service.

The conflict in West Asia began on February 28, when joint US-Israeli strikes targeted Iranian military and leadership sites.

Chaim Rafalowski, Disaster Management Coordinator at Israel's national emergency medical service, Magen David Adom (MDA), said on Monday that 16 fatalities have been

Pak offers to host talks to end Iran conflict

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE/AGENCIES
■ New Delhi

Shehbaz Sharif has said Pakistan is ready to host negotiations aimed at ending the ongoing conflict involving Iran, signalling Islamabad's intent to play a proactive diplomatic role amid rising regional tensions. In a post on X, Sharif said Pakistan would be "ready and honoured" to facilitate talks between Iran and the United States, subject to the agreement of both sides.



Palestinians inspecting the wreckage of an Iranian missile that landed in the West Bank village of Kifl Haris

are proud, victorious and steadfast in defending Iran's integrity, and this path will continue until complete victory." The general did not say what "complete victory" would look like, but it appeared likely Iran's military was trying to warn against offering concessions in any possible negotiations with the United States.

Iran targets Israel, Gulf Arab states

A missile slammed into a street in central Tel Aviv as Iran kept up its barrages targeting Israel and Gulf Arab states on Tuesday, even as President Donald Trump said the United States was in talks with the Islamic Republic to end the war.

Russia fires nearly 400 drones at Ukraine

ILLIA NOVIKOV ■ Kyiv

A major Russian drone and missile attack on civilian areas of Ukraine killed four people and injured at least 27, officials said Tuesday.

Moscow's army stepped up efforts to break through Ukrainian front-line defence in what could be the start of an anticipated spring ground offensive. Russia fired almost 400 long-range drones at Ukraine overnight, Ukraine's air force said, in its biggest attack in weeks.

The onslaught continued into Tuesday morning as dozens of drones targeted the capital Kyiv during daylight. Russia also launched 23 cruise missiles and seven ballistic missiles at Ukraine



during the night, hitting at least 10 locations across the country, according to the air force.

Ukrainian civilians have endured relentless barrages since Russia launched a full-scale invasion of its neighbour more than four years ago. US-brokered talks between Moscow and Kyiv over the past year have brought no respite, with Russia rejecting Ukraine's

offer of a ceasefire and in recent weeks the Iran war has diverted international attention from Ukraine's plight. On the roughly 1,250-kilometer front line snaking along eastern and southern parts of Ukraine, the short-handed defenders have been bracing for a new offensive by Russia's bigger army as the weather improves.

The Commander-in-Chief of Ukraine's armed forces, General Oleksandr Syrskiy, said Russian troops in recent days have made simultaneous attempts to break through defensive lines in several strategic areas. "Fierce fighting unfolded along the entire line of contact," Syrskiy said

Monday on messaging app Telegram, with Russia launching 619 attacks in four days.

"The occupiers are attempting to bring up new units and are preparing to continue attacks," Syrskiy said, adding that Ukraine had deployed reinforcements to counter the assaults. The Institute for the Study of War, a Washington-based think tank, said Syrskiy's report backed up its assessment that Russia's spring-summer offensive is now underway.

Russia has escalated its strikes since March 17 and has moved heavy equipment and more troops to the front line, the ISW said late Monday. (AP)

Trump raises hopes for war to wind down but no sign of reduced fighting

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Hopes rose that the Iran war could begin winding down as US President Donald Trump claimed that his government was holding productive talks with Tehran, but fighting showed no signs of slowing and Iran denied there were talks.

Trump extended his deadline for Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz on Monday, saying the US will hold off striking Iranian power plants for five more days to allow US envoys to hold talks with a "respected" Iranian leader.

Iranian officials said that the American leader had backed down "following Iran's firm warning". Relief ripped through financial markets Monday as oil prices eased following severe losses prior to Trump's announcement. Markets have experienced vicious swings up and down since the war began because of uncertainty about how long it may last. The



death toll has risen to more than 1,500 people in Iran, more than 1,000 in Lebanon, 15 in Israel and 13 US military members, as well as a number of civilians on land and sea in the Gulf region. Millions of people in Lebanon and Iran have been displaced.

Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi since Monday has been talking with his counterparts in Azerbaijan, Egypt, Oman, Pakistan, Russia, South Korea, Turkey and Turkmenistan, his office confirmed.

China protests alleged break-in at its embassy in Tokyo

MARI YAMAGUCHI
■ Tokyo

China says it has protested to Japan over an alleged break-in at the Chinese Embassy in Tokyo.

An individual who claimed to be a Japan Self-Defence Forces officer scaled the wall and forced his way into the embassy compound on Tuesday morning, Lin Jian, a Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson, said in a news conference in Beijing. Tensions between the two Asian nations have escalated in recent months after Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi said in



November a Chinese military action against Taiwan could constitute "a survival-threatening situation" for Japan requiring the use of force. Beijing, which regards the self-governing island as part of its territory, has since stepped up diplomatic and trade reprisals against Japan.

Japan's NHK public television said the suspect, believed to be a soldier in Japan's army or the Ground

Self-Defence Force, was detained on the spot and handed over to Tokyo police for further investigation. Nobody was injured, according to the TV report.

The man allegedly climbed the embassy wall and a knife was left behind, NHK reported. TBS television said the suspect carried an SDF identification card. Police are investigating the case as a suspected trespass, Japanese media said.

Tokyo police refused to confirm the report or comment on the case. The Ground Self-Defence Force told The Associated Press it was aware of the report and

currently investigating but couldn't comment on it. "China is deeply shocked by the incident and has lodged solemn representations with the Japanese side, expressing strong protest," Lin said.

"The Japanese side has failed to properly manage and discipline its Self-Defence Forces personnel and has not fulfilled its responsibility to ensure the security of Chinese embassies and consulates and their staff," Lin demanded Japan immediately investigate the incident thoroughly, punish the individual involved, provide an explanation to China and take preventive measures. (AP)

7.6-magnitude quake hits South Pacific ocean

CHARLOTTE GRAHAM-MCLAY
■ Wellington

A strong preliminary magnitude 7.6 earthquake struck near Tonga in the South Pacific Ocean on Tuesday, prompting coastal evacuations but no wider tsunami warnings.

The United States Geological Survey said the quake struck early Tuesday evening local time at a depth of about 237 km. Earthquakes at shallower depths are felt more strongly at the surface.

The jolt was centred at sea, 153 km west of Neiafu, the second largest town in the island nation. There were no



immediate reports of damage. Tonga's National Disaster Risk Management Office warned all in the low-lying island nation to move immediately to higher ground or inland.

People should avoid beaches, shorelines, and low-lying coastal areas until an all-clear was given, said a

post on the office's Facebook page. The USGS did not issue a tsunami warning for the region, and the Pacific Tsunami Warning Centre in Hawaii said in a bulletin that there was no tsunami threat because the quake was "located too deep inside the earth." Tonga is an archipelago in Polynesia made up of

171 islands with just over 100,000 people, most of whom live on the main island of Tongatapu. Tuesday's quake was centred nearer to the Vava'u island group.

A person who answered the phone at the Tanoa International Dateline Hotel on the beachfront at Nuku'alofa, which is on Tongatapu, said she wasn't aware of any damage.

"The whole building shook. No further damage. Everything was ok," she said. Tonga is situated on the Pacific Ring of Fire, the arc of seismic faults where much of the world's earthquake and volcanic activity occurs. (AP)

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Karan Arora to inform the public at large that Mr. Karan Arora is purchasing the Residential House No. 844/27, MCG Property ID-IC7M2027, area measuring 64 sq. yards, situated in the residential colony known as Madanpuri, Teshil & District Gurugram, Haryana from Mr. Gagan Bhatia and Mrs. Heena who became owner through Sale Deed dated 08.05.2024 (Doc No. 1458) executed by Shri Milan Adlakha and same will be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., Noida. That Original Sale Deed dated 29.08.2006 executed in favour of Shri Narayan Dass s/o Shri Chhiman Lal (Doc No. 11430) has lost. So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc.

Lucem Legal LLP
B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank
Sector 2, Noida, UP-201301 Contact: 96120-4269379

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Sayam Jain to inform the public at large that Mr. Neeraj Jain & Mr. Puninder Sain Jain are the owners of the Flat No. B11404, Admeasuring 1679 Sq. Ft., on 14th Floor, in Tower No. B1, Situated at Tulip Grand, Sector 35, Sonapat, Haryana and same to be financed & mortgaged by Fedibank Financial Services Limited. That, Mr. Puninder Sain Jain & Mrs. Sudha Jain became the owners of the said property through Conveyance Deed Dated 11.01.2018 (as Doc. No. 4558) executed by M/S Tulip Infratech Pvt. Ltd. Further, Mrs. Sudha Jain Expired on dated 23.06.2023 leaving behind her legal heirs namely Mr. Neeraj Jain (Son) & Mr. Puninder Sain Jain (Husband). To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections within 7 days, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc.

Lucem Legal LLP
B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank
Sector 2, Noida, UP-201301 Contact: 96120-4269379

STATE BANK OF INDIA

HOME LOAN CENTRE-CUM-SARC II, CORRENTHUM BUILDING, GROUND FLOOR, SECTOR-62, NOIDA, DISTT.- GAUTAM BUDDH NAGAR, U.P.-201301

PHYSICAL AUCTION NOTICE FOR SALE OF MOVABLE PROPERTY ON 27.03.2026

Sale Notice for Sale (Auction) of Movable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with provision to Rule 6(2) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", As is What is" and Whatever there is" on 27.03.2026, for recovery of bank due to the secured creditor from **MS. MONIKA MISHRA**. The Reserve Price will be **Rs.5,50,000/- (Rupees Five Lakh Fifty Thousand Only)** ('GST as applicable) and the Earnest Money Deposit will be **Rs.55,000/- (Rupees Fifty Five Thousand Only)** Demand Draft in favour State Bank of India.

The Vehicle are available for inspection during banking hours on 26.03.2026 From 11:00 AM to 04:00 PM.

VEHICLE DESCRIPTION

Make & Model : MAHINDRA BOLERO NEO N10(R)

Registration No. : UP14FU9738

Engine No. : XZP6K99433

Chassis No. : MA1NA2XZXPK94417

Date of Registration : 09.11.2023

Kilometer Run : 49446

Fuel : Diesel

VEHICLE AUCTION PLACE

ADDRESS: G-27, FLAT NO.104, PANKAJ TOWER, 4 DDA COMMUNITY CENTRE, VIKAS PURI, WEST DELHI-110018

For any queries please contact: (KUBER CONSULTANT) (Resolution Agent) (Mr. Rahul Pal/ Mr. Rakesh Mob: 9810807622 / 9868598282)

Date: 24.03.2026

Place: NOIDA

Sd/- Binay Pathak, Chief Manager/Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, RACPC 2, Noida

Colombia military plane crash toll reaches 66

MANUEL RUEDA
■ Bogota (Colombia)

A military transport plane with 128 people on board, mostly soldiers, crashed shortly after taking off Monday in Puerto Leguizamo, Colombia, killing at least 66 people and leaving dozens injured, the head of Colombia's armed forces said. General Hugo Alejandro Lopez Barreto said that four military personnel were still missing.

"Sadly, as a consequence of this tragic accident, 66 of our military elements died," he said. "At the moment, we have no information, or indications, that it was an attack by an illegal armed group," Barreto added. In a video



People standing around a military cargo plane that crashed after taking off from Puerto Leguizamo, Colombia, a remote municipality in the Arzazonian province of Putumayo

posted on social media, Deputy Mayor Carlos Claros said that the bodies of the victims were taken to the small town's morgue, and that the only two clinics in

town treated the injured before they were flown to larger cities.

Puerto Leguizamo is located in Putumayo, an Amazonian province that borders Ecuador

and Peru. "I want to thank the people of Puerto Leguizamo who came out to help the victims of this accident," Claros told Colombian television station RCN. Defence

Minister Pedro Sanchez said on X that the plane that crashed Monday was transporting troops to another city in Putumayo.

Images shared online by Colombian media outlets showed a black cloud of smoke rising from a field where the plane crashed and a truck with soldiers rushing to the site. The airplane had 128 people on board, including 115 were from the Army, 11 crew members and 2 from the National Police. Bareto said 57 people were evacuated. Media outlets shared videos of soldiers being rushed from the site on motorcycles driven by local residents, while another group of residents tried to put out the fire that the plane crash had created in a

field surrounded by dense foliage. Carlos Fernando Silva, the commander of Colombia's air force, said details of the crash were not yet known, "except that the plane had a problem and went down about two kilometers from the airport."

The air force commander added that two planes, with 74 beds, were sent to the area to fly the injured back to hospitals in the Capital, Bogota. Petro seized on the accident to promote what he called his longtime campaign to modernize planes and other equipment used by his country's military, saying those efforts have been blocked and suggesting that some officials should be held accountable. (AP)

US SC sounds sceptical of late-arriving ballots



MARK SHERMAN ■ Washington

The Supreme Court's conservative majority sounded sceptical of state laws that allow the counting of late-arriving mail ballots, a persistent target of President Donald Trump. A ruling, likely to come by late June, that bars counting ballots arriving after Election Day would send officials scrambling in 14 states and the District of Columbia, just a few months before the 2026 midterm congressional elections to change their ballot rules.

An additional 15 states that have more forgiving deadlines for ballots from military and overseas voters also could be affected.

The legal challenge is part of Trump's broader attack on most mail balloting, which he has said breeds fraud

despite strong evidence to the contrary and years of experience in numerous states. Trump has repeatedly claimed that his loss to Joe Biden in 2020 resulted from fraud even though more than 60 court decisions and his own attorney general said that argument had no merit.

The court heard arguments in a case from Mississippi pitting the state against Trump's Republican administration and the Republican and Libertarian parties. At issue is whether federal law sets a single Election Day that requires ballots to be both cast by voters and received by state officials. "While there was no explicit reference to the 2020 election, several conservative justices gave voice to some of Trump's complaints.

Bangladesh's influential ex-army general arrested

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

An influential former military general who played a key role in 2007 in installing an army-backed interim Government replacing a caretaker one, which was presumed to be inclined to the BNP, now headed by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, has been arrested, police said on Tuesday.

Police said their men in plain clothes arrested retired Lieutenant General Masud Uddin Chowdhury, one of the key figures instrumental in changing the Government in 2007 and installing an interim one that ran the country for the subsequent two years until the 2008 elections.

"The detective branch arrested him (Chowdhury) last night from his Baridhara residence (in Dhaka). He has been arrested in relation to five cases which have been lodged against him," the branch's chief, Shafiqul Isam, told reporters.

He, however, did not explain the charges against Chowdhury, who later served as Bangladesh's ambassador to Australia and subsequently became a member of parliament from the Jatiya Party.

The Jatiya Party was an electoral ally of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina's now disbanded Awami League, which won with a two-thirds majority in the December 2008 elec-



tions. The military-backed interim Government following a virtual behind-the-scenes army coup known as 1/11 is believed to be intended to enforce a "minus two formula" to discard two top leaders of Awami League and Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP), Hasina and her arch-rival ex-premier Khaleda Zia.

During the nearly two-year rule of the then-interim Government, incumbent premier Rahman too was arrested, allegedly tortured in custody and accused of several criminal and graft charges.

Chowdhury was then the coordinator of the National Coordination Committee on Serious Crimes, under which anti-corruption drives were carried out. Rahman eventually was exiled in the UK,

where he spent 17 years and returned home in December last year, five days before his mother Zia's death after prolonged ailments.

The BNP entrusted him with the charge of heading the party after Zia's demise, and came to power in the February 12 election, grabbing two-thirds of parliamentary seats under his leadership.

During the previous interim Government of Muhammad Yunus, a court last July ordered the confiscation of Chowdhury's movable property.

The ex-general's arrest came as the then-army chief General Moeen U Ahmed has been exiled in the United States, and at least two influential military officials staying abroad.

229 migrants calling for help found in back of truck in eastern Mexico

ALBA ALEMAN
■ Xalapa

Mexican authorities found 229 migrants on Monday packed in the back of a truck travelling through the eastern state of Veracruz, the first such encounter in months, marking a potential uptick in migration since US President Donald Trump took office.

Jose Manuel Pozos, the state's deputy Government secretary, said that they found migrants trapped in a truck reported stolen after they began to call for help from a police impound lot. Most of the migrants were



from Central America, 17 were minors and a number were dehydrated, he said.

Veracruz is one of a number of states that masses of migrants have historically crossed to reach the United States, and are

preyed upon by cartels and other criminal groups. They are often packed into trucks in dangerous conditions to evade authorities while being smuggled north.

But as migration north has plummeted since Trump took office, cases are few and far between.

An employee at the Xalapa vehicle impound lot, where the truck was taken, told The Associated Press that the trailer had been stopped about 45 kilometres southeast of the city and that hours after arriving at the lot, workers began to hear shouting and banging coming from inside. (AP)

Rebels in Congo used containers to hold journalists in brutal conditions

MARK BANCHEREAU
■ Dakar

A rebel group in eastern Congo has detained civilians, including two journalists, in metal shipping containers without light or ventilation, an advocacy group said on Tuesday.

Reporters Without Borders, or RSF, said the Rwanda-backed M23, which controls parts of eastern Congo, used the containers in the city of Goma as makeshift detention cells under "inhumane" and "degrading" conditions.

Using witness accounts, satellite imagery and photos collected in 2025, RSF said at



least two journalists were among those detained in the containers, which were installed at the compound of the province's legislative assembly in Goma.

Witnesses' identities have been withheld for security reasons. As many as 80 detainees at a time were placed inside a container, without light or ventilation and allowed out only once

a day. Witnesses said they received minimal food, while some reported routine beatings. According to the testimonies, conditions were extreme - suffocating heat by day and cold at night - with deaths reported. Survivors were often held for weeks before being transferred to other locations.

The M23 did not immediately respond to a request by The Associated Press for comment.

The rebels' takeover of Goma last year has worsened conditions for journalists operating in eastern Congo, where threats and attacks were already widespread. (AP)

Kim vows to irreversibly cement North Korea's nuclear status

KIM TONG-HYUNG
■ Seoul

North Korean leader Kim Jong Un has pledged to irreversibly cement his country's status as a nuclear power while maintaining a hard-line stance toward South Korea, which he called the "most hostile" state, State media said on Tuesday.

In a speech to Pyongyang's rubber-stamp parliament, Kim accused the United States of global "State terrorism and aggression," in an apparent reference to the war in the West Asia, and said the North will play a more forceful role in a united front against Washington amid rising anti-American sentiment. But Kim didn't call out US President Donald Trump



by name and said whether his adversaries "choose confrontation or peaceful coexistence is up to them, and we are prepared to respond to any choice."

His comments largely aligned with his statements at last month's ruling Workers' Party Congress, where he vilified Seoul but left open the door for dialogue with the Trump admin-

istration, urging Washington to drop its demands for the North's nuclear disarmament as a precondition for talks.

State media said the Supreme People's Assembly, which concluded its two-day session Monday, passed a revised constitution but did not specify the changes.

There had been expectations the revisions would codify South Korea as a permanent enemy and remove references to shared nationhood. That's in line with Kim's hard-line stance after he declared in 2024 that the North would abandon its long-term goal of a peaceful unification with the South.

Analysts say Kim's vilification of South Korea reflects his view that Seoul, which helped arrange his first meet-

ings with Trump in 2018 and 2019, is no longer a useful intermediary with Washington but an obstacle to his push for a more assertive regional role.

He has also shown sensitivity to South Korean soft power, driving aggressive campaigns to block the influence of its culture and language among North Koreans as he seeks to tighten his family's authoritarian grip.

In his speech, Kim expressed pride in the country's rapid expansion of nuclear weapons and missiles in recent years, calling it the "right" choice to counter future threats and "hegemonic pursuits" by "gangsterlike" imperialists, a term the North often uses for the United States and its allies. (AP)

Record-smashing heat continues in US

SETH BORENSTEINAP
■ New York

After smashing March heat records in 14 States and the US as a whole, the gigantic heat dome that's baked the Southwest is creeping eastward and may end up being one of the most expansive heat waves in American history, meteorologists and weather historians said.

And it's not going away for awhile, maybe not till the middle of the next week as April starts, said meteorologist Gregg Gallina of the National Weather Service's Weather Prediction Centre.

"Basically the entire US is going to be hot," Gallina said Monday. "The area of record temperatures is



extremely large. That's the thing that's really bizarre."

This heat dome - in which high pressure is acting like a pot lid trapping hot air over a region - will leave Flagstaff, Arizona, with 11 or 12 straight days of temperatures higher than the city's previous March record, said meteorologist Jeff Masters of Yale Climate

Connections. Gallina said the dome's eastward movement will mean temperatures in the mid-30s Celsius by Wednesday over the southern and central plains.

From one-quarter to one-third of the 48 continental States will be flirting with records for March, Gallina said. (AP)

1,000-year-old temple lies battered after Cambodia-Thai border clashes

SOPHENG CHEANG
■ Preah Vihear (Cambodia)

It's been three months since a ceasefire ended bitter border fighting between Cambodia and Thailand, but signs of combat are cut deep in this 11th-century temple atop a 525-metre cliff in the Dangrek Mountain range.

The neighbouring Southeast Asian countries have been fighting over Preah Vihear temple on and off for decades, and that's putting the ancient holy site in danger. Built by the same Khmer Empire that constructed Angkor Wat 160 kilometres southwest, the temple was declared a UNESCO World Heritage site

in 2008 and are held as an important cultural relic by Cambodians.

But after two rounds of major combat last year, much of the structure is damaged and Cambodian officials say that parts of it may be in danger of collapse. There's lots of wreckage, but no tourists Where tourists once admired the weather-beaten structure's elaborate carvings and a magnificent view over the Cambodian plains, there is now stone debris, artillery craters, and the ashes of burnt vegetation.

"The temple has turned quiet, and its beauty looks so sorrowful because of the tragedy," Hem Sinath, arche-



Cambodian police officers walking past a temple damaged during border clashes with Thailand, at Preah Vihear province

ologist and deputy director-general of the National Authority for Preah Vihear, told Associated Press journalists visiting earlier this month. The site is closed to tourism due to unstable walls and concern about the

presence of unexploded ordnance. Areas are roped off and dotted with signs warning of land mines, a hazard Cambodians know well after decades of civil war that ended in the late 1990. Conservation staff,

groundskeepers and troops remain stationed in and around the temple, from which Thai soldiers can be seen just across the border.

All five of the temple's notable gateway pavilions were damaged, three almost beyond recognition, according to a damage assessment issued in January by Cambodia's Culture Ministry. An ancient northern staircase previously restored by a US-funded conservation project sustained severe hits from repeated bombardment.

A statement issued last week by Cambodia's Culture Ministry said the temple had suffered damage in 142 locations during the fighting in

July, and at 420 more during heavier and more sustained combat in December.

"Experts have predicted that during the upcoming rainy season, some structures on the verge of collapsing could finally fall," Hem Sinath said.

No independent outside evaluations of the damage are available.

Cambodia charges temple was deliberately attacked Information Minister Neth Pheaktra accused the Thai military of relying on false information to justify incursions and of deliberately damaging the temple.

"Preah Vihear temple belongs to all humankind. It is not an enemy of

Thailand," he wrote.

International law forbids attacks on important historical sites like the temple, but Thailand has argued that Cambodia militarised the temple by installing weapons systems, storing ammunition, and using the site as a base for surveillance equipment, voiding its wartime protection.

This included a tall construction crane at the site, which the Thai army attacked after claiming it served as part of a military command and control system.

Thai Army spokesperson Major General Winthai Suwaree has insisted that Thai forces directed their fire strictly at military targets. (AP)

US shipyard workers strike over wages

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Portland

Hundreds of designers, clerks and technicians went on strike in Maine at one of the US Navy's largest shipbuilding contractors. The Bath Marine Draftsmen's Association went on strike at General Dynamics Bath Iron Works after members voted to reject the shipyard's proposed wage offer over the weekend.

The union represents 627 workers at the historic shipyard, which has built naval



ships in Bath for more than a century. The strike arrived several weeks after a morale-boosting appearance in which US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth touted the need to boost defence manufacturing.

The union said in a statement that the shipyard's offer does not address the members' concerns about wages. "We had hoped the company took to heart the statements made by Secretary Hegseth at GD BIW because, our membership certainly did," union President Trent said in an emailed statement that also said General Dynamics "continues to make record profits off our labour".

PROSPECT

Indian student changemakers leveraging AI for good

Ashoka Innovators for the Public and Connecting Dreams Foundation successfully organised the National Student Change Initiatives Festival 2026 at the EMPI Business School Campus, New Delhi, bringing together hundreds of university students changemakers from across India to showcase innovative, AI-enabled solutions to some of the country's most pressing challenges. A total of 100 student teams comprising over 250 students from 14 different States travelled to participate in the festival, each presenting AI-enabled prototypes developed to address real-world problems within their communities.

The SocioFare Awards for selfless service and social impact

Delhi: The 4th edition of the SocioFare Awards was held on 21 March at India International Centre, celebrating individuals and organisations driving grassroots social impact. Organised by Sabri Helpage, the event brought together changemakers, including senior defence personnel, journalists, and educationists. Founder Aarti BR Singh highlighted the platform's mission to amplify unheard voices and recognise silent contributors to society. Key awardees included Dr Raman Kishor (healthcare access), Nischay Foundation (menstrual hygiene), PVCHR (human rights), Mahesh Foundation (HIV care), Guria India (child welfare), SHEWOS (elderly care), Chhanv Foundation (acid attack survivors), and Deepalaya (education and women empowerment). "Chacha Chachi Chandra Dhaba" was honoured for lifetime service. The event reinforced the importance of grassroots efforts, collaboration, and continued commitment toward building an inclusive and equitable society.



IRFC signs ₹12,842 crore refinancing deal with HURL



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In one of its largest-ever refinancing initiatives, the Indian Railway Finance Corporation Limited (IRFC) has signed a Rupee Term Loan agreement with Hindustan Urvarak and Rasayan Limited (HURL) for a staggering ₹12,842 crore.

The deal, aimed at refinancing HURL's existing long-term debt, was formalised in the national Capital between Sunil Kumar Goel, Executive Director (Finance), IRFC, and Poonam Jeswani, CFO, HURL. The signing took place in the presence of the Chairman and Managing Director of IRFC, Manoj Kumar Dubey, and the Chairman of HURL.

Speaking on the occasion, Manoj Kumar Dubey stated that the Navratna CPSE is actively expanding its footprint to support infrastructure sectors with strong railway linkages.

"This transaction reflects our 'whole-of-Government' approach, bringing cost-effective, long-term financing to strategically important sectors like fertilisers. By enabling financial efficiency, we are contributing

to agricultural sustainability while strengthening logistics with railways at the core," he said.

The move is part of the 'IRFC 2.0' strategic vision, which seeks to diversify the corporation's role as a financier beyond core rail projects to include power, mining, and multimodal logistics. HURL, a joint venture of PSUs including NTPC, Coal India, and Indian Oil, operates revived fertiliser plants in Gorakhpur, Sindri, and Barauni—all of which rely heavily on the Indian Railways for freight movement.

The refinancing is expected to provide HURL with competitive terms and an optimised repayment structure, enhancing its debt-servicing efficiency and freeing up resources for future growth.

Established in 1986, IRFC continues to maintain a zero-NPA portfolio while mobilising resources at competitive rates to bolster India's infrastructure. This latest partnership reinforces its position as a critical financial partner in the Government's nation-building initiatives.

FIR against Experion Developers & Experion Capital for rigging insolvency process

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a major law enforcement action, the Economic Offences Wing (EOW), Delhi Police on Monday registered a case under Sections 420 and 120B of the Indian Penal Code, 1860 against M/s Experion Developers Private Limited (EDPL), M/s Experion Capital Private Limited (ECPL), and others, following a formal complaint filed by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED), under Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002.

The FIR, registered at the Economic Offences Wing, PS Mandir Marg, New Delhi, arises from what the ED has characterised as a systematic manipulation of the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) of M/s Dignity Buildcon Private Limited (DBPL)—a company owning approximately 27.86 acres of prime land in Sector 62, Golf Course Extension Road, Gurugram, valued conservatively at over ₹630 crore.

According to the ED's complaint which forms the basis of the FIR, EDPL and its related entity ECPL—both wholly-owned subsidiaries of the AT Capital Group controlled by Arvind Tikku—orchestrated



ed a multi-layered scheme to capture DBPL's insolvency process at near-zero cost.

While EDPL itself had obtained a stay on the CIRP from the Delhi High Court ostensibly to challenge the IBC—its own related entity ECPL simultaneously used the stay period to acquire the majority debt position in the Committee of Creditors (CoC). ECPL purchased Standard Chartered Bank's ₹490 crore exposure in DBPL for a mere ₹160 Crore, vaulting to 49.3% voting rights in the CoC. This fact was never disclosed to the NCLT.

Not satisfied with a bare majority, ECPL then acquired the Blackstone Group's debtenture holdings in DBPL for ₹25 crore against admitted claims of ₹58 crore, pushing its CoC voting share to 60%. It then proceeded to acquire

61% of the Security Receipts of the XXXIX Trust—the vehicle through which Alchemist ARC (holding 35.4% CoC votes) had structured its position—for a mere ₹18.02 crore.

Through this acquisition ECPL gained de facto control over Alchemist ARC's voting discretion in the CoC, giving the Experion group combined influence over ~95% of CoC votes.

The ED's complaint records that ECPL wrote to Alchemist ARC on 24.01.2023, directing it to consult ECPL before voting on any resolution plan.

Most damningly, Sachin Gupta, the Authorised Representative of Alchemist ARC, admitted in his statement recorded under Section 50 of the PMLA on 23.08.2024 that ECPL compelled Alchemist ARC to vote in favour of EDPL's resolution

plan. With the CoC under its control, EDPL's bid of ₹660 crore was approved—despite competing bids of ₹760 Crore (Madhav Dhir/Alok Dhir) and ₹709 crore (M3M Group) being substantially higher.

The legitimate bidders were effectively disenfranchised by a manipulated voting process.

The ED's analysis of EDPL's payment flows reveals that of the total ₹445 Crore stated to have been paid to creditors under the resolution plan, ₹261.8 crore flowed back to ECPL (for its 60% CoC stake) and ₹38.92 crore flowed back to ECPL (for its 61% Security Receipt position)—meaning the Experion group essentially paid itself with plan proceeds.

The net effective outflow by the Experion group for acquiring a ₹630+ Crore land asset was a fraction of the stated plan value.

The land in question had already been attached by the ED, in connection with the diversion of approximately ₹150 crore from Religare Finvest Limited (RFL) by the Singh brothers (Malvinder Mohan Singh and Shivinder Mohan Singh), funds used to purchase this very land.

India, Russia deliberate on next-gen smart urbanisation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The third edition of the Smart Cities Forum, held at The Oberoi in the national Capital, brought together a distinguished assembly of global policymakers, industry experts, and stakeholders to chart the future of sustainable, technology-driven urban development.

The forum not only highlighted the role of cities as engines of economic growth but also reinforced the strate-

gic urban partnership between India and the Russian Federation.

The session, moderated by Alexey Bondaruk, Head of the Moscow Centre for International Cooperation, featured key speakers including Rajya Sabha MP Ram Chander Jangra, Russian Ambassador to India HE Denis Alipov, and senior officials from both New Delhi and Moscow.

Addressing the gathering, Rajeev Jain, former Director General of the Press



Information Bureau and the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, delivered a compelling overview of India's Smart

Cities Mission. He emphasised that the initiative has transcended mere infrastructure to build "aspiration and confidence" among citizens.

Providing a snapshot of the mission's scale, Jain revealed that India has successfully operationalised 100 Smart Cities. "Over 8,000 projects have been sanctioned, with more than 7,500 projects completed—representing nearly 94 per cent implementation," he stated. He further noted that investments exceeding Rs 1.5 lakh

crore have been delivered, with Integrated Command and Control Centres (ICCCs) now functional across all designated cities.

Highlighting specific success stories, Jain cited Indore's transformation in waste management, Visakhapatnam's disaster preparedness, and the revitalisation of public spaces in Jammu and Kashmir. He also noted how smart mobility is bridging geographic hurdles in Northeastern cities like Shillong and Aizawl, while

Udaipur has successfully integrated heritage conservation with modern planning.

The forum underscored the pivotal role of ICCCs in enabling data-driven governance, particularly their efficacy during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Looking ahead, the deliberations focused on scaling these smart solutions city-wide, enhancing climate resilience, and deepening India-Russia collaboration in digital systems and sustainable urban infrastructure.

Jharkhand learners unveil smart-agri, health bots at State hack event

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Quest Alliance, in collaboration with the Jharkhand Education Project Council (JEPCC), organised the state-level event "Hack to the Future" in Ranchi. It brought together young learners, educators, Government officials, and civil society organisations to explore innovation and future readiness in education.

A key highlight was the live exhibition of student-developed prototypes, where learners showcased their ideas and engaged directly with stakeholders. Around 35 students and 9 teachers from Ramgarh, Dumka, and Deoghar presented solutions to real-world challenges using design thinking and technology, demonstrating creativity, critical thinking, and problem-solving.

Prototypes included solutions like a Smart Agriculture Recommendation System and Smart Drip Irrigation System to support farmers with crop decisions and efficient water use; a Water Body Cleaning Robot to tackle local pollution; and health and safety innovations such as an AI-Based Health Monitoring Box for adolescent girls and a Wild Watch Defence System to prevent crop damage from animals.

Speaking at the event, Neha Parti, Director of the Schools Program at Quest Alliance, shared insights on India's vision for 2047. She highlighted a rapidly transforming world shaped by automation and artificial intelligence. "While technology is expected to take over instruction-based tasks, human creativity, decision-making, and ethical judgement will remain

critical," she said. Youth voices added powerful perspectives. During an interactive session, a learner shared: "I imagine that robots will take over petty jobs and we may have to work regularly, just with the robots."

Dr Avinash Kumar, State Program Officer (SPO) at Jharkhand, attended as Chief Guest and highlighted key challenges in the education landscape. "Only 11.92 per cent of students opt for science in Class 12, indicating the need to strengthen STEM engagement," he said. The event reinforced the importance of strengthening partnerships between Government, schools, and communities, with a key priority of supporting teachers through practical approaches that enable meaningful integration of future-ready skills into classrooms.

Vijay Goel meets PM, presents coffee table book on Vajpayee

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Former Union Minister and Vice Chairman of Gandhi Smriti and Darshan Samiti, Vijay Goel, met Prime Minister Narendra Modi at his office in Parliament House on Tuesday. On the occasion, Goel presented to the Prime Minister the recently published coffee table book on Atal Bihari Vajpayee's life, titled Atal Bihari Vajpayee: The Eternal Statesman.

Goel said that they held a detailed discussion on various contemporary issues, and he congratulated the Prime Minister for his extraordinary contribution to the service of the nation.

Goel said that Modi is among the select leaders of the country who have rendered uninterrupted public service for nearly 8,930 days while holding various offices, thereby creating a new



record for leading the Government for the longest period. This includes his tenure as Chief Minister of Gujarat and as Prime Minister of India.

Goel also said that in the present time of global crisis, the entire nation stands united under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and appreciates his guidance.

He further described the

Prime Minister's role during the Covid-19 pandemic as highly commendable, noting that he handled the country effectively and led it out of the crisis.

He further said that at a time when the world is entangled in various conflicts and wars, the Prime Minister, through his strong diplomacy, has successfully safeguarded India's interests and strengthened the country's position.

Galgotias students land dream jobs as top corporates drive strong placement season

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Greater Noida

Amid intensifying competition in the job market, Galgotias University has sustained a strong placement momentum this year, with several leading national and global companies recruiting students across tech-

nology, consulting, finance and engineering domains.

The university has expanded its industry engagement and employability initiatives in recent years, enabling students to transition more effectively from classrooms to corporate careers.

Officials say the institution has established multiple centres of excellence in collaboration with industry partners on campus, a move that has strengthened skill development and contributed to consistent placement outcomes.

According to university representatives, a large number of companies participated in campus recruitment drives this season, offering opportunities in emerging technology and business sectors. Recruiters included firms such as Infosys, Cognizant, Accenture, EY, Capgemini

and over 1,200 other organisations associated with the university's hiring ecosystem.

Placement records from the university indicate that the highest package for the current year is recorded as 60 lakh per annum. In addition, several other students received niche job offers ranging between ₹15 lakh and ₹26.6 lakh per annum from the companies of high repute.

The Galgotias Placement department also shared detailed hiring figures from major recruiters. Around 526 students were placed at Infosys, 228 at Capgemini, 205 at Cognizant, 119 at Larsen & Toubro Mindtree (LTM), 188 at City Union Bank, 91 at Accenture and 61 at Ernst & Young. Officials attribute these outcomes to the university's and college's (GCET) student-

centred active learning ecosystem, which combines practical training, industry exposure and academic learning. The model has been developed in collaboration with Inspire at Nanyang Technological University, Singapore.

Beyond placements, Galgotias is also focusing on fostering innovation through entrepreneurship and startup initiatives, encouraging students to explore technology-led ventures and build scalable business ideas.

Education analysts note that institutions aligning academic programs closely with industry needs are increasingly attracting recruiter attention. In this context, Galgotias University continues to position itself as a hub for talent development and professional readiness.

Border Brew Café inaugurated in Zemithang, Arunachal Pradesh



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

In a significant step towards promoting community development and sustainable tourism in remote border regions, the Indian Army has inaugurated the Border Brew Café under Operation Sadbhavna in Zemithang, Arunachal Pradesh. The project is dedicated to the welfare and empowerment of the local Monpa tribal community.

What makes the Border

Brew Café truly unique is its innovative construction on a decommissioned Bailey Bridge over the River Nyamjang Chu. This pioneering concept seamlessly blends heritage infrastructure with modern utility, making it one of its kind in the entire Northeast region. The café is poised to emerge as an iconic destination for tourists and travellers exploring this scenic frontier area.

Developed with a vision to generate sustainable liveli-



hood opportunities, the café actively involves the local community while promoting tourism in the region. The initiative is expected to enhance economic prospects for residents by showcasing local culture, traditions, and hospitality.

Demonstrating remarkable efficiency and commitment, the Indian Army completed the project in a record time of just 31 days, reflecting exceptional planning, coordination, and execution.

The initiative embodies the core ethos of Operation Sadbhavna, which focuses on fostering goodwill, strengthening civil-military relations, and contributing to the socio-economic development of border communities.

The inauguration ceremony witnessed enthusiastic participation from local residents, dignitaries, and Army personnel, marking a proud and promising milestone for Zemithang and the region at large.

BRIEFLY

2028 Los Angeles Olympics announces its official look



The 2028 Los Angeles Olympics has announced its official look, and it's a blast of bold colours. The graphic patterns and color palettes will be used to identify everything from credentials to staff uniforms to signage to competition venues and the athletes village. The concept announced Monday is based on a California superbloom, a phenomenon that occurs every 10-15 years in the spring and results in a vibrant explosion of wildflowers across hills, valleys and deserts. The LA28 design team studied past Olympic and Paralympic Games, including the 1984 Los Angeles Games, to inspire the look. The orange Bird of Paradise, the city's official flower, inspired the primary colors used in the concept as well as the 13 blooms that make up the full Superbloom.

Asian Champions League Elite to be moved to Jeddah



Four Asian Champions League Elite series that were postponed due to the war in the Middle East will be moved to Jeddah, Saudi Arabia and played on a single-leg basis next month, the Asian Football Confederation said on Tuesday. The last-16 matches had originally been scheduled to be played in Qatar, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates on a home-and-away basis in the first two weeks of March. Those matches will now be held on April 13 and 14 as single legs ahead of the tournament's finals stage. Defending champions Al-Ahli are scheduled to take on Al-Duhail from Qatar while four-time champions Al-Hilal face Al-Sadd. Shabab Al-Ahli from the UAE plays Iran's Tractor FC and Al-Wahda meets Saudi Pro League champions Al-Ittihad. Jeddah had already been scheduled to host the quarterfinals, semifinals and final with matches running from April 16-25. Last-16 matches on the Eastern side of the draw have already been played, with Japanese sides Vissel Kobe and Machida Zelvia joined in the quarterfinals by Thailand's Buriram United and Johor Darul Ta'zim from Malaysia. The draw for the quarterfinals will be held in Kuala Lumpur on Wednesday. The AFC Champions League Two and AFC Challenge League quarterfinals were also postponed due to the Mideast war. The AFC said Tuesday that those matches will be played on April 19 and 22 at centralised venues to be named at a later date.

Stokes describes past 3 months as hardest period of captaincy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

England Test captain Ben Stokes has described the past three months, which involved a difficult Ashes campaign, as the "hardest period" of his leadership journey while reiterating his commitment to rebuild the side with coach Brendon McCullum.

After the England and Wales Cricket Board (ECB) confirmed that Stokes, McCullum and managing director Rob Key would continue in their roles despite England's 4-1 drubbing in the Ashes, the 34-year-old shared an emotional open letter on social media on Monday.

"Being England captain is the greatest honour a player can be given and I do not take it for granted. It has its highs



and it has its lows, it makes you want to smile it makes you want to cry," Stokes said in post with a picture of himself, Key and McCullum on Instagram.

"It completely and utterly consumes you and feels like it's the only thing in your life at times. The last 3 months has without a doubt been the

Gattuso says no alibis for World Cup playoff

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Rome

Coach Gennaro Gattuso acknowledged that only "someone without blood running through their veins" wouldn't feel nervous as Italy attempt to avoid failing to qualify for a third consecutive World Cup.

Gattuso is still just as feisty and gritty as when he played on the Italy team that won the country's fourth World Cup in 2006.

Ahead of Thursday's playoff match against Northern Ireland, he also suggested he sent home talented winger Federico Chiesa in what could amount to a definitive break with the standout player of the European Championship

trophy run five years ago. "It's undeniable that there's nervousness," Gattuso said Monday. "Only someone without blood running through their veins wouldn't feel it. But we need to do a good job of transmitting a lot of positivity."

Positivity, however, is not what describes Italy's performances in the playoffs for the previous two World Cups, when the Azzurri were eliminated by Sweden and North Macedonia, respectively.

Italy is in jeopardy at the same stage for the coming World Cup in North America after two losses to Norway in qualifying. The Azzurri need to beat Northern Ireland at home in Bergamo and then Wales or Bosnia and



Herzegovina away next week to avoid going at least 16 years without even playing a match at soccer's biggest event. "There are no alibis," Gattuso said. "It's useless to think if we could have done better. The only thing we should be thinking about is

Thursday's game. Forget that we've won four World Cups, two Euros and an Olympic title. For us, the only game is Thursday's."

"All of the players that are here today know what we're playing for and how important it is."

Boxer Sio out of medically induced coma

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ San Bernardino (US)

The promoter and family of junior flyweight boxer Isis Sio say she is awake and breathing on her own after initially being placed in a medically induced coma following a knockout loss last weekend. Sio is still in intensive care, but the 19-year-old is no longer on a ventilator, ProBox TV announced in a news release Monday.

Sio was stopped by Jocelyn Camarillo just 78 seconds into their bout at San Bernardino's National Orange Show Event Center last Saturday. "Isis remains in ICU, but she is off the ventilator and we are hopeful for her progression," Sio's camp said in its release. "We



are awaiting further updates from her medical team. She is currently under the care of three specialised medical divisions who are closely monitoring her condition."

Sio, who was born in North Dakota, has lost three of her four professional bouts since her debut last September. She was also

stopped by Perla Bazaldua on Jan. 26 in Long Beach, leading to widespread online speculation about why Sio was allowed to fight again so quickly. Sio's camp responded to that speculation Monday by clarifying that Bazaldua stopped Sio with a body shot, rather than a head shot.

Williams likely for India debut; Jamil names squad for Hong Kong qualifier

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Australian-born forward Ryan Williams could make his much-anticipated India debut after being named in head coach Khalid Jamil's 23-member squad for the AFC Asian Cup 2027 Qualifier against Hong Kong on March 31 in Kochi.

Williams was included in the squad after FIFA cleared his change of association, paving the way for the 31-year-old winger to represent India at the senior international level. He had earlier been part of India's preparatory camp for the Bangladesh qualifier but missed out on the lineup due to pending documentation. With all formalities

now complete, he is in line to make his debut against Hong Kong. Already ruled out of qualification for the Asian Cup, India will look to sign off their campaign on a positive note with a blend of experience and youth in the squad.

Williams, whose mother hails from an Anglo-Indian family in Mumbai, will thus become only the second foreign-born footballer of Indian origin to play for the country after Japan-born Arata Izumi, who represented India between 2013 and 2014. A versatile attacker currently playing for Indian Super League side Bengaluru FC, Williams relinquished his Australian passport last year to play for India. Born in Perth in 1993, Williams began



his professional journey in England after joining Portsmouth's academy in 2010. He broke into the senior side a year later, making his debut against Middlesbrough, before going on to have stints with clubs such as Fulham and Barnsley. On the international stage, Williams represented Australia at the youth level, featuring in the 2012 AFC

U-19 Championship and the 2013 FIFA U-20 World Cup.

His only senior appearance for Australia came in a 2019 friendly against South Korea, a non-competitive fixture that allowed him to switch national allegiance under FIFA rules.

The Blue Tigers began their camp in Kochi on Tuesday where 20 players along with

the staff, have assembled.

Defender Anwar Ali, midfielder Jeakson Singh Thounaojam, and forward Edmund Lalrindika, who played their last ISL match against Mohammedan Sporting Club on Monday will join the squad later on Tuesday. "This is a good opportunity for us to build for the future," India head coach Jamil stated in a release.

"We have a lot of promising players coming through, who are currently with the U20 and U23 national teams, playing in the SAFF U20 Championship in Maldives, and the U23 Tri-Nation in Arunachal Pradesh.

"Our assistant coach Mahesh is himself leading the U20s, which will help us

familiarise them with the system we have in place here with the senior team."

Squad:
Goalkeepers: Albino Gomes, Gurpreet Singh Sandhu, Vishal Kaith.

Defenders: Abhishek Singh Tekcham, Akash Mishra, Anwar Ali, Bijoy Varghese, Nikhil Poojary, Rahul Bheke, Roshan Singh Naorem, Sandesh Jhingam.

Midfielders: Ashique Kuruniyan, Danish Farooq Bhat, Jeakson Singh Thounaojam, Lalengmawia Ralte, Sahal Abdul Samad.

Forwards: Edmund Lalrindika, Farukh Choudhary, Lallianzuala Chhangte, Liston Colaco, Manvir Singh, Rahim Ali, Ryan Williams.
Head coach: Khalid Jamil.

India land in Maldives for SAFF U20 Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Male (Maldives)

The Indian Under-20 men's football team has arrived here for the SAFF Championship and will square off against traditional foes Pakistan in its opening match here on Thursday. After this game, the Blue Colts will face Bangladesh on March 28 in the Group B of the tournament that kicked off on Monday.

Both matches will be played at the National Stadium here.

Group A consists of hosts Maldives, Sri Lanka, Nepal and Bhutan. The top two teams from each group will qualify for the semi-finals



that will take place on April 1. The final will be held on April 3. "This is a very important and prestigious tournament for us. All teams are very competitive. We have to perform well," India U20 head coach Mahesh Gawali said. The 23-strong squad

has also begun training to adjust to the humidity and coastal weather expected to test all participating sides. "It's not that we are the only team that is going to play in such conditions. So we have to be ready," Gawali said.

Learning curve for both athletes and officials at inaugural National Indoor Championships

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH
■ Bhubaneswar

Young shot putter Omkar Prasad Nanda resorted to using a worn-out shoe, while runner C Priyanka relied on her experience of training on a curvy track, as athletes and officials adjusted to an unfamiliar setting at the inaugural National Indoor Championships, which began on Tuesday.

Nanda was among the fortunate few who had been training at the state-of-the-art indoor stadium hosting the championships, as he resides at the residential hostel attached to the facility.

He has been training here for the last 10-14 days but is

still mindful of the possibility of slipping on the throwing circle made of wood.

"The throwing circle in outdoor events is made of cement and so there is grip with your shoe and you have more confidence. But in indoor events, the throwing circle is made of wood and is a little bit slippery. So, you have to be careful that you don't slip and get injured," said Nanda, who won gold in U-20 section with a throw of 17.77m. "It can be slippery when you start rotating. If everything is OK at the start of rotation, I get good ascent and distance.

"Luckily, I did not slip today, may be because I have gotten used to it as I've been train-

ing here for the last 10 to 14 days," said the Odisha athlete who made his debut indoor competition.

"I also wore an old shoe which I have been using for around two and a half years so that the sole is little worn out and thus has grip. A new shoe may be more slippery," added Nanda, whose father works in the police department. On the difference between indoor and outdoor events, he said, "Competition environment is same. But as a thrower, we get wind support outdoors and not in indoors." Nanda has a outdoor personal best of 18.23m. "It is the same technique, no different approach for indoor events while train-



ing but the platform is different." For senior women's 3000m run gold winner Priyanka, past training experience on 200m tracks, though outdoor, helped. "The track

here was a very nice experience, I did not get any tightness. Since we normally run in 400m track, the 200m track was little more curvy. For that we have to adjust," said the

Karnataka athlete who emerged winner with a time of 9 minute 42.05 seconds.

"I had trained at 200m track at the SAI Bengaluru and there is one more 200m track at the Kanteerava Stadium in Bengaluru. When I was a junior, I used to train there, it helped me." Middle and long distance run is about patience, tactics and 120-150m acceleration. For middle and long distance, we don't use lane number 5 and 6 as these have slopes. Usually, we use lane number 1 obviously."

Learning curve for officials also: The Athletics Federation of India (AFI) has a vast experience of organising national and international events,

but it was also a learning experience for the officials while organising the National Indoor Championships.

"I will not say that it is a very challenging but a learning experience for us also as it is the first indoor event in the country.

The rules and regulations are the same, the logistics are almost the same. "The only difference is the 200m track which are sloped and more curvy than the outdoors 400m track," said AFI treasurer and technical committee member Stanley Jones. "In indoors, there is not impact from winds, temperature and weather variations, it's a more controlled and consistent environment.

Moreover, there will be no impact of rain in indoors and that is a plus point as compared to outdoors. "On the other hand, indoor events are held one after the other and there is not much gap between the two sessions in a day. Since it is a much smaller space, you can't hold too many events together.

In outdoors, you can hold jump or throw events together but not in indoors. There is no space." **Interesting case of shot put measurement:** In outdoor events, there is a clear mark on the sand or soil where the iron ball lands and measurements are made accordingly for the shot put competition. (PTI)

T20I rankings: Smriti retains 2nd spot, Harmanpreet rises to 14th

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

Swashbuckling India batter Smriti Mandhana retained her second spot, while skipper Harmanpreet Kaur moved up to 14th in the latest ICC women's T20I rankings for batters released on Tuesday.

Apart from Mandhana, the big-hitting Shafali Verma was the other Indian in the top 10, holding on to her sixth position, while Jemimah Rodrigues remained joint 11th.

Among bowlers, spin all-rounder Deepti Sharma climbed one spot to third

with pacer Renuka Singh Thakur retaining her sixth place. Seamer Arundhati Reddy, however, slipped out of the top 10 to 11th.

Deepti also rose to number 3 in the all-rounders' rankings.

Australia opener Georgia Vull entered the top 10 of the batting rankings for the first time while New Zealand star Sophie Devine's two successive half-centuries against South Africa helped her move up two places to 18th in the list.

The latest rankings update that takes into consideration the first two matches of the series in the



APART FROM MANDHANA, THE BIG-HITTING SHAFALI VERMA WAS THE OTHER INDIAN IN THE TOP 10, HOLDING ON TO HER 6TH POSITION

West Indies, also saw the 15-year-old Fanny Utagushimaninde of Rwanda enter the rankings on 66th position after becoming the first woman to score a century on T20I debut (against Ghana) and the youngest of either

gender to score a century in the format.

The ICC Emerging Player of the Year in 2024, Annerie Dercksen, moved up 18 places to 55th after an unbeaten 55 in the fourth match of the series in New Zealand.

All-rounders Ellyse Perry of Australia (up two places to 20th) and Qiana Joseph of the West Indies (up 14 places to 33rd) made notable progress in the batting rankings, with Maddy Green (up two places to 44th) and Stafanie Taylor (up two places to 48th) also registering gains.

The T20I bowling rankings saw left-arm spinner

Nonkululeko Mlaba enter the top 10, her five wickets in three matches lifting her from 11th to ninth while Australia leg-spinner Georgia Wareham moved from 16th to 12th after picking three wickets in two matches.

New Zealand's Jess Kerr has attained a career-best 15th position after grabbing eight wickets in the first four matches of the series against South Africa that includes a series-clinching three for 16 in Wellington.

Ayabonga Khaka (up five places to 36th) and Kim Garth (up 35 places to 44th) have also advanced.

RCB players to wear jersey No 11 for practice to honour stampede victims

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Royal Challengers Bengaluru players will train wearing jersey No.11 during match days in the upcoming IPL and the franchise also plans to mark 11 permanent seats in honour of the fans who died in a tragic stampede outside the M Chinnaswamy Stadium here last year.

The fans had lost their lives on June 4 in a stampede that was triggered by chaos during RCB's celebratory events after the team's maiden IPL trophy win. The franchise had copped massive criticism for its handling of the celebrations which drew lakhs to the streets without requisite security clearances.



"The players will be wearing jersey No.11 for the practice on the game day — the practice time before the match," RCB CEO Rajesh Menon told reporters here on Tuesday.

"All the players will have jersey No.11 on their back; not for the game, but for the practice."

"Apart from that, they will be also wearing black sunglasses on that day. We are also looking at having 11 permanent seats in Chinnaswamy Stadium forever. This is for the 11 fans who will be with us forever," he added.

RCB pacer Yash Dayal to miss IPL 2026: Mo Bobat

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Controversial pacer Yash Dayal will not join the Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) squad for the upcoming IPL but he remains contracted to the squad, the franchise's Director of Cricket Mo Bobat said on Tuesday.

The 28-year-old Dayal, who is facing two cases of alleged sexual exploitation, has not played any competitive cricket since appearing in the IPL 2025 final that RCB won to be crowned champions for the first time.

"So just to confirm that Yash will not be joining up with the squad. As you know, he is going through a personal situation currently, and just to clarify, we've been very supportive of Yash to date, and that's reflected in

the opportunity to either retain or release players," said Bobat in the season-opening press meet here on Tuesday.

"We wanted to retain him, and he remains under contract and will continue, you know, in the short term, foreseeable to remain under contract," he added.

Dayal, who got married recently, has been accused of sexual exploitation by two women, one of them a minor teenager. Bobat said the franchise has kept the line of communication open with him.

"We are communicating with him regularly, you know, I spoke to him earlier today as well. But it has been decided that it is not in his best interest, or in the franchise's best interest, for him to join up with us at this point.



"We won't be making any other further comments on that at this stage. But he obviously retains our support, he remains under contract, and we'll continue to speak to him as he goes through his personal situation," he explained.

Bobat said they have enough depth in their ranks to cover for Dayal.

"If we were thinking of domestic replacements, if that's what we were looking to do, then I mentioned Rasik (Salam), Abhinandan

Singh and Mangesh (Yadav). There's three very good options.

"All three of those have had excellent preparatory camps so far. So we've kept all our options open. I enjoyed scouting Mangesh in the off-season, prior to the auction," he said.

Nonetheless, Bobat admitted that Dayal, who was the joint highest wicket-taker for RCB in the 2024 season, would be missed.

"...it's obviously a blow, losing a player like Yash. He's been an important part for us for the last couple of years, but we're very confident in the options we've got in the squad," he said.

Bobat also hoped that pacer Josh Hazlewood will be able to join the squad at the earliest after completing his recovery process.



Invested approx ₹7 crore to improve crowd management at Chinnaswamy: RCB CEO

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Royal Challengers Bengaluru CEO Rajesh Menon on Tuesday said the franchise has invested nearly Rs seven crore to enhance the crowd management infrastructure in and around the M Chinnaswamy Stadium which witnessed the death of 11 fans in a stampede during the team's IPL trophy celebrations last year.

RCB and the Karnataka State Cricket Association (KSCA) were forced to enhance security measures after the stampede on June 4, 2025 near the stadium. During the upcoming IPL, the reigning champions are scheduled to play five matches here, starting with this season's inaugural match against Sunrisers Hyderabad on Saturday.

"We have invested approximately ₹7 crore towards enhancing crowd management infrastructure, including multiple baggage scanners and command centres," Menon said in the pre-season press meet here.

He said the RCB will ensure a safe and seamless match-day

experience for fans at the stadium, even though the highly popular pre-season 'Unbox' event has been cancelled.

"We have significantly strengthened crowd management measures. We have implemented AI-led CCTV solutions across the stadium, including inside, the concourse, and surrounding areas, powered by an AI tool called Jarvis. "This system provides real-time alerts, including stand-specific crowd counts, to ensure better monitoring and control. These CCTV feeds will also be accessible to the Commissioner's office for real-time monitoring," he said.

Menon said the franchise has adhered to all the parameters laid down by the Karnataka state government and the High Court.

"I would like to thank the government for making this possible. It has been a long journey since June 4, and everything has been executed on a war footing. We have worked to follow the SOPs provided by the court and ensure all protocols are in place," he assured.

Langer backs Pant to excel in second year as LSG skipper

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Rishabh Pant becomes unmatched as a cricketer when he plays with a smile on his face says, Lucknow Super Giants (LSG) head coach Justin Langer, backing the Indian wicketkeeper-batter to have a better year at the helm of the franchise in IPL 2026.

Pant became the costliest player in IPL history when he was bought by LSG for a whopping price of ₹27 crore last year. But there wasn't much to cheer for Pant and LSG in IPL 2025 as they finished at seventh position on the points table.

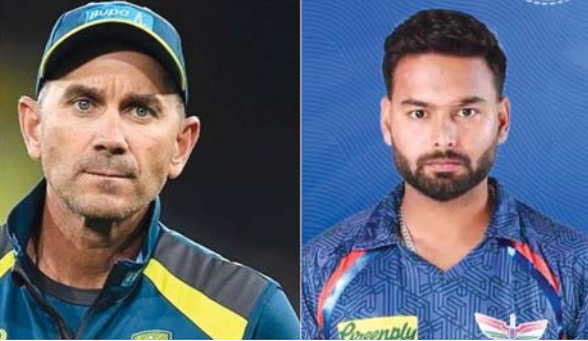
Langer said while Pant was "trying hard to impress"

last year, the stint also helped the franchise and their coaching staff understand more about him.

"If we see Rishabh laughing, smiling and having fun, he'll be a brilliant captain, and that's what we learned last year. He (had) joined a new franchise, trying hard to impress, which is natural," Langer told JioHotstar.

"But we're already seeing a lighter Rishabh (now). He knows the players now and we have got his back. He's smiling a lot and dancing. When he's like that and starts playing cricket, there's no one more exciting to watch in the world," he added.

With a top order consisting Australia T20I captain Mitchell Marsh, his South



African counterpart Aiden Markram and former West Indies skipper Nicholas Pooran, Langer said LSG's batting was "No.1" last year but they still could not go the distance which led to the team making amends in the auction.

"We had a very good auction and that's where it starts. We had a great base last year. I think our batting was No.1 in the competition last year. (But) we weren't able to capitalise on that," he said.

"But this year, we've added

to our squad. There will be some really tough selection calls. But if our batting can keep firing and our bowling can keep developing, then we've got a very good team."

The former Australian opener said Mohammed Shami's presence is vital for all young bowlers in the team.

"During the team lunch, Mohammed Shami was speaking and all the boys were hanging on his every word, their eyes never left him," Langer remarked.

"He's incredibly experienced (and) a true warrior. We often discuss big brother-little brother or master-apprentice dynamics in coaching, and that's exactly what we have here."

Langer expressed confidence in coaching staff's work behind the scenes with bowlers who are coming off injury lay-off. India speedster Mayank Yadav is one of those who has had a considerable time away from the game.

"In recent years, pretty much every bowler has arrived post-surgery or injury, building momentum during the season," Langer said.

"But this pre-season, we've established a top medical department under Patrick Farhart. Tom Moody, our new director of cricket, built this squad at the auction with elite professionalism. Bharat Arun isn't just a bowling coach; he's the mentor and the general."

US-based Kal Somani-led consortium to acquire Rajasthan Royals for \$1.63 billion

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

IPL franchise Rajasthan Royals is set to be sold to US-based Kal Somani-led consortium for a whopping \$1.63 billion (approx ₹15,290 crore).

The Somani-led consortium includes Rob Walton from the Walmart family and Hamp family (Ford). Somani is an Arizona-based tech entrepreneur who has founded IntraEdge, Truyo.AI and Academian.

The other contenders were Times Internet-led consortium, the Aditya Birla Group and the Mittal family led by ArcelorMittal CEO Aditya Mittal.



The sale of Rajasthan Royals is subject to approval from the BCCI and will come into effect after the 2026 edition. British-Indian Manoj Badale held a 65 per cent

stake in the Royals.

"Kal is an existing investor in the franchise. The deal is subject to approval from the BCCI and will be signed soon. The price of USD 1.63

billion reflects how far the IPL has come as a brand," a well-placed source told PTI.

"If you look at the sale of the latest IPL entrants Lucknow Super Giants, it is way more than that. It just shows remarkable growth of the league," shared another source drawing a comparison with sale of LSG to RPSG Group for little over ₹7000 crore back in 2021. "I expect the deal to be announced in the next four to five days," he added.

Another major IPL franchise, defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru, is also up for sale and the value of that deal is likely to cross USD 2 billion.



Mbappe says injury has healed as France ramps up for World Cup

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris

As the World Cup looms, France star Kylian Mbappe says his left knee that bothered him for weeks is now fine. The Real Madrid striker was used as a substitute in his team's last two matches as he works his way back into form and has joined his France teammates ahead of a couple of friendlies in the United States this week.

"There was a lot of frustration, a lot of anger, and then also some anxiety at one point," Mbappe told French media late Monday at a promotional event. "I had reached a stage where I didn't know what was wrong with me. I didn't go through that period in the best way. I wasn't the happiest player in

the world. But I'm happy now because it's truly behind me. It's all gone."

Mbappe had been in great form until he sprained his knee at the end of last year. The former Paris Saint-Germain player, who joined Madrid in the summer of 2024, played throughout January but was then sidelined for three-and-a-half weeks before making his latest comeback.

"I wanted to be very cautious so as not to come back too quickly and risk a relapse or pick up another injury elsewhere," he said. "I wasn't afraid of reinjuring my knee, but of getting hurt somewhere else, because after four or five weeks without playing, you have to get all the other muscles going again. That's why I took my time."

Indian shooters set for season-opening Shotgun World Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Tangier (Morocco)

Bhowneesh Mendiratta will aim to put the Paris Olympics heartbreak behind him and kick off the year on a high as he leads the Indian charge at the season-opening ISSF Shotgun World Cup, with an eye on a busy calendar culminating in the Asian Games and the World Championships later this year.

Trap marksman Bhowneesh, who had

secured India's first quota for the Paris Olympics but missed out in the trials, will be keen to hit the ground running in Tangier as the qualification cycle for the Los Angeles 2028 Olympics gets underway this year.

India is sending a 12-member squad for trap and skeet across the men's and women's events, along with two trap mixed teams, supported by a large contingent of foreign coaches, physiotherapists, and psychologists,



even as top trap shooter Zoravar Singh Sandhu misses out on the lineup.

Last year, veteran trap shooter Zoravar became only the third Indian to win a World Championships medal, clinching bronze and joining the legendary Karni Singh and Manavjit Singh Sandhu in India's elite shooting history.

The 46-year-old, currently ranked fourth in the world by the International Shooting Sport Federation (ISSF), faces

a tricky path to the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya this September-October, as team selection for the continental event requires participation in World Cups, meaning skipping them could jeopardise his qualification despite being India's top trap shooter.

With the National Rifle Association of India securing a green light from the Indian embassy in Morocco despite tensions in the Middle East, safety shouldn't be an issue, but on paper, the team